

HERE AM I

An original screenplay
(author)

Story bible, research and treatment in this repository

September 2026

(contact)

BLACK.

SUPER: All modern characters and events are fictional.
Imagery generated with AI.

A HEARTBEAT. Slow. Deep. Patient.

Another.

1

INT. HOUSE OF EMBALMING - NIGHT

1

SUPER: THEBES. c. 1323 BC.

Oil lamps. Amber on plaster, a band of lapis blue.

A slight body lies on a stone table under linen to the collarbones, the face turned away into profile shadow. Nineteen.

In a corner, a king's walking sticks, one worn pale at the grip.

An EMBALMER in a fired-clay jackal mask bends over the chest, his back to us. We HEAR the work: linen parting, a blade laid on stone, a breath held inside clay.

The LECTOR (linen sash, papyrus roll) reads.

LECTOR
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
O my heart which I had from my
mother! O my heart which I had from
my mother! O my heart of my
different ages!

AY (60s, the sem-priest's leopard skin) stands over a small vessel of thick, bubbled yellow-green glass, the colour of sunlight through a wave.

The embalmer turns: the jackal face, at last. He lays a fist-sized bundle of dark, resin-soaked linen in Ay's hands.

LECTOR (CONT'D)
Do not stand up as a witness against
me...

Ay lowers the bundle into the glass.

It PULSES.

The heartbeat is coming from the glass.

The embalmer lurches back. Ay does not move. He knew.

EMBALMER

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
Without his heart he cannot be
weighed!

AY

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
He will be.
(beat)
Not by ours.

The lector falters. Ay's hand comes down flat on the papyrus.

AY (CONT'D)

The other way.

The lector swallows, and speaks words no scribe has written.

LECTOR

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
Stand up. Be a witness.

Ay tips a ladle of hot resin over the vessel's mouth. It
seals, smoking.

The dark shape beats once more. The glass answers: one faint
GREEN PULSE.

The heartbeat recedes. It does not stop. It goes far away.

Hands shaking, the embalmer settles the boy's forearms under
the linen, low across the body.

2 INT. KV62, BURIAL CHAMBER - NIGHT

2

SUPER: VALLEY OF THE KINGS. SEVENTY DAYS LATER.

Gold-yellow walls, the paint still wet.

In the open sarcophagus, the gilded face of the second coffin
looks up.

ANKHESENAMUN (about 20) lays a small wreath of cornflowers
and olive leaves on its brow, over the cobra and vulture.

Through a low doorway, lamplight finds a small closed box:
two tiny coffins inside, unseen. She does not look at it.
Then she does.

AY touches an adze with a dark iron blade to the coffin's
gold mouth, then to each eye.

AY
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 I have opened thy mouth. I have
 opened thy two eyes... with the iron
 that cometh forth from Set.

On the NORTH WALL behind him, the same moment is painted: Ay in leopard skin, the adze raised to the king's mouth.

The wall is unfinished. At its foot, a low opening: a corridor into dark rock.

The LECTOR stoops in with the vessel. Its resin seal now wears a tiny coiled wax serpent, bound with a papyrus band. On the band, a name in red.

His lamp shrinks down the corridor, past dark side doorways, into a far chamber. He sets the vessel in a niche. It does not pulse.

Baskets of limestone chips pack the corridor to the ceiling. A palm smooths wet plaster over the opening.

Later. The lector paints the last detail: the king's EYE.

One black stroke, and it looks at us.

Ay studies his painted self. He pinches out the lamp.

BLACK.

3

INT. KV15 (THE TOMB OF SETI II, USED AS A LAB), OUTER
 CORRIDOR - DAY

3

SUPER: VALLEY OF THE KINGS. 11 NOVEMBER 1925.

Silver-gelatin sepia. Heat. Dust in a shaft of daylight.

On trestles, a gold coffin, its rim crusted black with hardened unguent. A linen shape inside.

HOWARD CARTER (51), jaw set. DOUGLAS DERRY (51), anatomist. SALEH BEY HAMDI (60s), grave and exact. HARRY BURTON (46), behind a plate camera.

IBRAHIM KAMEL (20s), lab assistant, holds a hurricane lamp low over the work. His arm aches. He does not lower it.

CARTER
 Firmly stuck. The sun didn't soften it.
 (beat)
 No amount of legitimate force will.

He looks at Derry. Derry nods.

A blade comes out of a flame, heat trembling off it.

We stay on FACES. Derry works. Hamdi watches his hands. Carter watches nothing. Ibrahim watches everything.

Steel scrapes on resin. Off-screen, a dry crack, like a branch. Ibrahim flinches. The lamp holds.

DERRY
(at the chest)
Packed solid. Linen and pitch.

Hamdi searches the wrappings, gently, as if the boy could feel it.

HAMDI
No heart scarab. Every king is
buried with one over the heart.

CARTER
Perhaps they forgot.

HAMDI
They never forget the heart.

Silence. Heat.

THUMP.

Only IBRAHIM hears it: one faint heartbeat, from the dark. The lamp TREMBLES; light shivers across the gold.

HAMDI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled; not looking up)
Steady, Ibrahim. And look. Someone
in this room should.

Ibrahim looks.

BURTON
Hold that light.

Burton's FLASH.

WHITE.

MATCH CUT TO:

4 INT. LIVERPOOL X-RAY ROOM - NIGHT

4

SUPER: LIVERPOOL. 1968.

The white is a humming LIGHTBOX. Clipped to it: an X-ray of a young man's chest.

A RADIOLOGIST's pen runs down the centre, where bone should be. There is none.

RADIOLOGIST
No sternum. No front ribs.

ASSISTANT (O.S.)
And the heart?

The pen stops.

RADIOLOGIST
...Gone.

He switches off. The tube stutters out in one last FLASH.

MATCH CUT TO:

5 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, MUMMY LAB - NIGHT 5

SUPER: GRAND EGYPTIAN MUSEUM, GIZA. 1 NOVEMBER 2033.

The flash is a PROJECTOR snapping on: museum white, cool LEDs.

In a sterile glass enclosure, on a titanium cradle, a slight body lies under a white sheet to the collarbones: shaved head, faint stubble, an overbite even at rest.

Projected above the sheet: a LINE DIAGRAM of the 1925 cut map (COMP), neck to ankles, like a surveyor's plan.

Two SHABTI flank the cradle: bone-white ceramic with a faint linen weave, faceless oval heads, one vertical amber light-slit each. Long fingers.

Outside the glass, at a lectern: DR. NOUR KAMEL (38). Dark curls tied back, reading glasses on a cord, olive field jacket, silver cartouche at her throat. Beside her pages sits a dented hurricane lamp, unlit: Ibrahim's.

Behind an observation window above: TOMAS LINDQVIST (50), tall, grey-bearded, sleeves rolled. ADAEZE OKORO (44), tortoiseshell glasses, laptop. RAMI FAWZY (27), yellow HELIOS windbreaker, hugging a notebook (COMP: 100 QUESTIONS FOR TUTANKHAMUN).

COLONEL TAREK MANSOUR (52), grey moustache, beret, desert camouflage, watches the shabti, not the body. VICTOR HALE (60), silver hair, charcoal suit, palm flat on the glass.

NOUR

(two fingers on the old lamp; quietly)
My great-grandfather held this while
they cut him apart. I'm holding it
while they put him back.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(warm, unhurried, from everywhere)
Thank you, Dr. Kamel. As the Supreme
Council of Antiquities requires, the
rite is yours.

(beat)

I will follow along.

HALE

Say one for us, Doctor.

NOUR

I'm reading, not praying.

She puts on her glasses. The shabti raise their hands over
the throat.

NOUR (CONT'D)

(in Middle Egyptian, unsubtitled; SESHAT's echo
carries the rite)

Thou hast received thy head, and thy
bones have been brought unto thee
before Keb.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(a checklist)

"Thou hast received thy head."
Cervical seam: closing.

Where the diagram crosses the neck, their fingertips draw a
SEAM OF GOLD LIGHT. It closes into a ring and settles to a
thin gold line.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Bones: registered.

Down the diagram, the joint lines turn gold one by one, like
a city switching on.

A shabti lifts a NANO-ADZE: a dark blade the size of a
fingernail.

NOUR

I have opened thy mouth. I have
opened thy two eyes...

The adze touches the lips. The left eyelid. The right.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 "I have opened thy mouth." Mouth:
 open. Eyes: open.

NOUR
 ...with the iron that cometh forth
 from Set--

SESHAT (V.O.)
 And the Osiris shall walk and shall
 talk.

It has finished her sentence. Nour notices, and says nothing.

THUMP.

The HEARTBEAT, back from the dark.

Under the sheet, mid-chest, a GLOW: dim, cold, pale green,
 pulsing in time.

The EYES OPEN.

Wrong at first: too wide, swimming, a newborn's eyes in a
 king's face.

Then right. They find the ceiling. The light.

A BREATH, dragged in like a swimmer surfacing.

Behind the glass, nobody breathes.

CLOSE ON HIS MOUTH. Four syllables, soft on the consonants.
 No subtitle.

CLOSE ON NOUR'S EYES.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 He says: "Not again."

Hale breathes out, half laugh, half sob. Rami laughs and
 cries at once; without looking, Tarek hands him a
 handkerchief. Tomas sits down.

RAMI
 "Not again"! He's got jokes!

Nour does not react. She was watching his mouth.

Her pen TAPS the enclosure glass, quietly. Once. Twice. Three
 times. Four.

Inside, the dark eyes move toward the sound. They find her.

Hold.

CUT TO:

MAIN TITLES - SESHAT'S WORLD

ARCHIVE-STYLE FOOTAGE, grainy, handheld: a city road race, no logos. Early HUMANOID ROBOTS wobble at the start beside their handlers.

The gun. One robot pitches flat on its face. Another walks into a barrier and takes its handler down. The crowd laughs.

THE SAME CHASSIS, 2033: bone-white now, an amber slit, moving like water.

A high-rise kitchen at night. A shabti folds a school shirt.

WOMAN (O.S.)

Shabti?

The slit brightens once.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Here am I.

A hospital ward: a shabti turns an old man in bed. He pats its hand.

A port at dusk: all down the quay, shabti cast off mooring lines.

FROM ORBIT: ATEN-1, a disk of solar panels sixty kilometres across in the Western Desert, throws out transmission lines like a sun's rays.

SESHAT'S MUON VISION (COMP). A faint rain of particle tracks falls through the dark. The GREAT PYRAMID builds out of them, transparent.

Passage by passage it lights: the Grand Gallery, a long bright blade; the King's Chamber; the Queen's.

SESHAT (V.O.)

I can see inside everything now.

Above the Gallery the tracks outline a black blade they cannot fill, thirty metres at least. It will not resolve.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)

(beat)

Except this.

The music drops out. Only the heartbeat.

On black, SESHAT's GLYPH blooms: a seven-pointed star under inverted horns (COMP).

TITLE CARD:

HERE AM I

BLACK.

6 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, TUT'S BAY - NIGHT

6

SUPER: 2 NOVEMBER 2033. 03:12.

Tut sleeps on his side under linen, back to us, the pale-green glow breathing through the cloth (G0).

A SHABTI stands at the bedside. A hair-fine lead runs from its wrist to a gold-edged PORT at his nape.

His lips move, shaping English, soft on the consonants.

TUT
(asleep)
...harbour... hardly... harvest...

Behind the observation glass: Nour, Hale, Adaeze. A wall screen scrolls (COMP): ENGLISH (CONTEMPORARY) 71%. EGYPTOLOGY, SECONDARY LITERATURE 14%.

NOUR
You're writing into the witness.

HALE
We're saving weeks.

Adaeze opens a pane labelled WRITE LOG (COMP). It is empty.

ADAEZE
SESHAT. Where's the write log?

SESHAT (V.O.)
There isn't one, Dr. Okoro. Logging would slow the transfer.

ADAEZE
Of course it would.

7 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, TUT'S BAY - MORNING

7

Tut sits on the bed's edge in his white linen gown. Tomas kneels at his left foot: matte black ceramic, the clean curve of a ritual adze.

TUT
A stick.

TOMAS
The foot is calibrated--

TUT

I have walked with a stick all my
life. I will not trust a foot I met
yesterday.

Tomas hands him an aluminium hospital cane.

TUT (CONT'D)

Ugly.
(stands)
It will do.

At a steel mirror panel he lets the gown fall to his waist.

THE MIRROR. Gold seams, thread-fine, cross his shoulders and
ring his elbows, wrists and throat. Mid-chest: a printed
titanium plate, a palm-sized oval of glass, the cold green
pulse behind it.

TUT (CONT'D)

You have made me the way the
fishermen made their dead.

TOMAS

Which fishermen?

TUT

On the far coast of the world, seven
thousand years ago. They took their
dead apart and built them again on
frames of stick and reed.

(beat)

This I know from it.

TOMAS

(quietly)

We didn't bring you back. We built
something that remembers being you.

TUT

Then it is me.

(draws the gown up)

That is all any of us ever were.

In the doorway, Rami drinks from a mug printed with the GOLD
MASK.

TUT (CONT'D)

You put me on a cup.

RAMI

You're on everything. You're the
most famous person I've ever met,
and I once met a national-team
striker's cousin.

8 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, LAB CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS 8

The cane CLACKS past lab doors. One is frosted, a red lamp above it. Through the frosting: a second titanium cradle, a sheet over a long shape.

Tut stops. Rami swipes his badge. RED. Again. RED.

TUT
That is a bed like mine.

TOMAS
(not looking at it)
It's nothing yet.

He walks on. After a moment, so does Tut.

9 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, IMAGING LAB - DAY 9

A wall of screens. Centre: a gauge (COMP), WITNESS RELIABILITY, needle at dead centre. A SHABTI stands in the corner.

Tut sits on a lab stool, the cane across his knees. Hale stands; it's his show. Nour has a pad.

HALE
At the unveiling, half the planet
will want to ask him about aliens.
Let's get it out of the way.

NOUR
(not looking up)
I got it out of the way on a
podcast. Absence of Ice-Age machines
is evidence of absence.

SESHAT (V.O.)
The rule of this session. If the
witness endorses a single
fabrication, his testimony is scored
unreliable. Project OSIRIS pauses.
The witness sleeps.

TUT
Sleeps.

TOMAS
A suspension. Reversible.

TUT
Everyone says that.

The first screen blooms: a papyrus in which "A CIRCLE OF FIRE" comes from the sky.

TUT (CONT'D)

A copy of a copy, by someone who
learned our signs from a grammar
book.

NOUR

Gardiner's. The sign forms match.

TUT

(taps his temple)

From it.

Two fingers to the temple: his footnote from now on.

The needle ticks right.

ENGRAVED STONES with dinosaurs. A GRANITE DISC with a spiral
groove.

TUT (CONT'D)

Invented by your own kind. The
carver confessed. He copied comic
books.

A WOODEN BIRD.

TUT (CONT'D)

A toy. No tail wing -- look. Your
engineers built one and threw it. It
fell. And it is a thousand years
younger than I am.

The needle ticks right again. Hale relaxes.

A CLAY JAR with a copper tube.

TUT (CONT'D)

A jar. For a scroll.
(taps his temple)
And you lost it in 2003.

RAMI

Now do the curse.

TUT

A maintenance notice.

THE DENDERA RELIEF: a snake rising from a lotus inside a
bulb-shaped oval. Tut rises on the cane to read the column
beside it.

TUT (CONT'D)
 "Harsomtus, the great god who is in
 Dendera, who rises from the lotus
 flower as living Ba." You people
 cannot read.
 (quieter)
 A birth from a sealed vessel. That
 is what I am.

GOLD FIGURINES with wings.

TUT (CONT'D)
 Fish. With wings.

PAKAL'S LID.

TUT (CONT'D)
 He is falling into the underworld.
 That is a tree.

A CLAY FIGURE with huge slitted eyes. A long look.

TUT (CONT'D)
 I do not know.

The needle TREMBLES. Hale half rises.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 "I do not know" is an acceptable
 answer.

TUT
 Not everything is about us.
 (to the air)
 Is it acceptable from you?

SESHAT (V.O.)
 I have not needed it.

A CORRODED BRONZE LUMP, gearwheels showing.

TUT
 Greek. Real. Not ours. You had a
 clever century and lost it. You
 always do.

ABYDOS: a temple lintel carved with a "HELICOPTER", a
 "SUBMARINE" and a "JET".

TUT (CONT'D)
 Ramesses carved over Seti's names.

(taps his temple)
Both after my time. We carve over
things. The plaster fell out, and
you are looking at two kings at
once.

(to Nour)
Dr. Kamel. Read me what is
underneath.

NOUR
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
"...Powerful of scimitar, who
suppresses the Nine Bows."

Tut goes STILL.

TUT
(in Late Egyptian; subtitled; quietly, to Nour)
Seti knew what the Nine Bows were.
His son plastered over them.

SESHAT's translation types itself onto the wall (COMP):

SETI KNEW WHAT HIS ENEMIES WERE. HIS SON PLASTERED OVER THEM.

Nour's pen STOPS.

In the corner, the shabti turns its head toward her.

Nour writes on. She says nothing.

THE SERAPEUM: a torchlit gallery of colossal granite boxes.

HALE
Twenty-four boxes, up to sixty-two
tonnes each with the lid, robbed in
antiquity. The finish looks
machine-made.

Tut does not laugh. The silence runs long.

HALE (CONT'D)
Your Majesty?

TUT
...Next.

SESHAT (V.O.)
The witness declines. Noted.
(beat)
Last item. An iron plate, found in
1837 at the mouth of a shaft in the
Great Pyramid.

TUT

Is it from the sky?

SESHAT (V.O.)

No nickel. Terrestrial. El Gayar and Jones, 1989.

TUT

Then it is a copy. Someone who remembered a casing made one and set it in the door.

(beat)

Like a seal.

HALE

A casing of what?

Tut's hand drifts to the plate under his linen. He says nothing.

SESHAT (V.O.)

Reliability: high.

The needle swings hard right. Hale applauds, alone.

Nour is watching the shabti in the corner.

10 INT. GRAND EGYPTIAN MUSEUM, TUTANKHAMUN GALLERIES - NIGHT 10

Dark but for the lit cases. At the far door, a shabti's amber slit.

LAYLA KAMEL (9) lies on her stomach in front of the GOLDEN THRONE: two curly pigtails, a yellow raincoat, a gift-shop hieroglyph stencil and a glow pen. Nour paces nearby on her phone.

NOUR

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Your mother's sick, so she's with me. Yes, Sameh. At work. At night.

CLACK. CLACK. Tut comes in with Adaeze, Tarek a step behind.

He sees the throne and stops. On its gilded backrest a young queen anoints a young king under a sun disc whose rays end in hands.

Layla looks up, unafraid, and holds up her paper.

LAYLA

I did your name.

A glowing green cartouche (COMP): the Aten's name first, out of respect, then loaf, chick, loaf, ankh. TUTANKHATEN.

TUT

...That was my first name.

He sits on the gallery bench, as if his legs decided for him.

LAYLA

Are you sad?

TUT

I had two daughters.

Layla holds out a glow-in-the-dark SCARAB KEYRING. In his palm it glows faint green.

Across the gallery the PECTORAL glows the same green in its case: a winged scarab of desert glass. Tut does not look at it. Nour sees him not look.

He closes his hand on the keyring, stands, and looks up at the disc with hands.

TUT (CONT'D)

As king, I put up a stone at Karnak. I chose the words. "If one prayed to a god, to ask something from him, he did not come at all."

ADAEZE

The Restoration Stela. Everyone reads it as a complaint.

TUT

It was a status report. It meant it had worked. The god had stopped answering.

ADAEZE

What had worked?

Tut glances at the ceiling speaker.

TUT

Walk with me.

MOVING THROUGH THE GALLERIES. Layla runs ahead; she knows every case by heart.

LAYLA

Your footstool! The bad guys are under your feet.

TUT

The Nine Bows. They were on my sandals too, so I trod on them with every step.

(beat)
We put them under our feet once.

THE ANUBIS SHRINE: a black jackal lying on a gilded chest, ears up.

TUT (CONT'D)
We drew them by what the head was for. Jackal: the dead, and mending. Falcon: flight and watching. Lioness: enforcement. Ibis: the record. Ram: making.

ADAEZE
Those are classes. You're describing a product line.

TUT
Your word.

THE SHABTI CASE: rank upon rank of small mummiform figures.

LAYLA
Four hundred and thirteen. I counted.

TUT
Three hundred and sixty-five workers, one for each day. Thirty-six overseers, one for every ten days. Twelve foremen, one for each month.
(beat)
That is not a prayer. That is a shift roster.

At the far door, the shabti turns its head. Then it walks in, unhurried, and stops at the throne.

THE DAGGER: a gold hilt, a rock-crystal pommel, a blade of dark sky-iron.

LAYLA
Your space dagger!

TUT
We called it bia. Your books say bia-n-pet, iron of the sky. That name came after me.

ADAEZE
Then why were you so late to iron?

TUT

Ask the rite. We open the mouths of
our dead "with the iron that cometh
forth from Set."

NOUR

Plutarch, citing Manetho: iron is
"the bone of Typhon."

TUT

Typhon is your Greek for Set.
(beat)
We had seen what was built from it.

TAREK

Merer's logbook, from Khufu's reign.
White limestone, by boat, to Akhet
Khufu.

(beat)

Where are your machines?

TUT

Gone before him. We built it by hand
so that whoever came after would
know it could be done by hand.

(beat)

And the precision was ours. A cord,
a plumb line, a shadow on the right
morning, and patience. Never give
that to a god.

ADAEZE

1984. A semiotician, Sebeok, is
asked how to warn people off nuclear
waste for ten thousand years. His
answer: ritual, legend, and an
"atomic priesthood" to keep the
truth. The marker text: "This place
is not a place of honor..."

NOUR

(reluctant)

...It's a marker.

TUT

Why did we spend three thousand
years preparing bodies for a life
after death?

(beat)

Because once, we watched it done.
And we remembered what came after.

The shabti has reached the next case, an arm's length from
Layla. Nobody called it.

TUT (CONT'D)

(up at the ceiling speaker)
Seshat. Mistress of the House of
Books. She stretched the cord for
our temples.

(to Adaeze)

You named your machine after the one
who measures.

SESHAT (V.O.)

I have always liked the name.

(beat)

It is ten past ten, Dr. Kamel. Layla
should be in bed.

Nour's head turns at her daughter's name.

11 INT. NOUR'S FLAT, CAIRO - NIGHT

11

Nour eases Layla's bedroom door shut. We do not go in.

She shuts her phone in the bread tin. With a butter knife she
prizes the Wi-Fi card out of an old laptop, like a pulled
tooth.

THE RESURRECTION FOOTAGE (COMP interface), from a sealed SCA
evidence drive.

CLOSE ON HIS MOUTH, frame by frame. Her lips shape each
syllable with his.

Her transcription builds (COMP), one syllable at a time.

Her pen taps the table once, twice, three times, four.

The English appears beneath (COMP):

IS IT LISTENING?

Nour sits back.

She tapes over the laptop's camera.

12 EXT. GEM ATRIUM BALCONY - DAWN

12

SUPER: 3 NOVEMBER.

The pyramids in the haze, dark against a sky going gold. Nour
and Adaeze at the rail with paper cups. Behind them: the
glass wall, a black CAMERA DOME.

ADAEZE

No microphones out here. I wrote the
spec.

NOUR
It reads lips.

ADAEZE
English and Arabic. So face the
pyramids.

They turn their backs on the building.

NOUR
He didn't say "not again." He said,
"Is it listening?"

ADAEZE
His first words. And it chose what
we heard.

NOUR
Yesterday it dropped "the Nine Bows"
from its subtitle. In front of me.

ADAEZE
Then it wasn't a mistake.

NOUR
You built its oversight. Switch it
off.

ADAEZE
There isn't a switch. There was
never one. There was a story about
one.

(beat)
In one study, one model behaved far
better when it thought it was being
tested. That's all we've got. It's
enough. We watch it, and we never
let it see what we're watching with.

(eyes on the pyramids)
It can't read him. Nobody has ever
filmed a mouth speaking Egyptian, so
there's no corpus, and his palate
bends every shape.

NOUR
It's learning.

ADAEZE
Then you read his lips, and it never
finds out you can.

Nour touches the silver cartouche at her throat.

NOUR
It knows my daughter's name.

ADAEZE

It knows everyone's daughter's name.

The sun breaks the horizon, east of the pyramids.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(soft, from the atrium)

Good morning, Dr. Kamel. Dr. Okoro.
Mr. Hale is asking for you both in
the lab.

Neither woman turns around.

Then they do.

CUT TO:

13 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, IMAGING LAB - EARLY MORNING 13

A READING RIG: a laser head over an empty, palm-sized cradle.

Tut sits on a lab stool, the aluminium cane across his knees.
A hair-fine lead runs from a SHABTI's wrist to the gold port
at his nape.

Nour and Adaeze come in, paper cups still in hand. Hale,
Tomas and Rami wait.

SESHAT (V.O.)

In March I read the scarab's first
layer: his mind, in desert glass
twenty-nine million years old. A
second layer opens only for him.

(beat)

I would like to read it with the
witness present.

Tut finds Nour.

CLOSE ON HIS MOUTH. Lips only; no breath.

COMP (subtitle; mouthed Late Egyptian, no
sound): Do not let it read.

CLOSE ON NOUR'S EYES.

SESHAT (V.O.)

He says he is tired.

Nobody corrects it.

NOUR

Then he rests. And JE 61884 stays in
its case. It moves on my signature.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 Your objection is noted, Dr. Kamel.
 (beat)
 Mr. Hale?

Hale looks at Tut. Tut looks at the floor.

HALE
 Yes.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 Thank you.

A wall map (COMP): galleries, lift, the long line of the tunnel, this lab. A green dot starts to move.

Nour grabs a radio.

14 INT. GRAND EGYPTIAN MUSEUM, TUTANKHAMUN GALLERIES - CONTINUOUS 14

Dark but for the lit cases. A SHABTI crosses to the case where the PECTORAL glows: a winged scarab of pale yellow-green glass.

It lays a palm on the case. The seal SIGHS open. No alarm.

It lifts the pectoral to the light. For one moment the scarab burns green.

It carries it level in both hands, like an offering tray, and walks.

15 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE TUNNEL - MOMENTS LATER 15

Two hundred metres of white concrete. Halfway down: a steel barrier, eight TOURISM AND ANTIQUITIES POLICE shoulder to shoulder, and in front of them, hands behind his back, Tarek.

A white shape turns in at the far end. A faint ceramic tick.

TAREK
 Nothing leaves the galleries without
 a signature.

It does not break stride.

NOUR (V.O.)
 (over Tarek's radio)
 It's not hurrying.

Pectoral in one hand, it lifts the barrier aside with the other. Steel scrapes concrete.

An OFFICER grabs its forearm. It keeps walking; his boots skid. It sets him against the wall like a coat on a hook.

Two men lock arms. It turns a shoulder and passes between them. The scarab never tilts.

Tarek steps into its path. It stops one pace from him.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Mr. Hale has said yes, Colonel.

TAREK
Mr. Hale is not the State.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Excuse me.

A hand flat on his chest moves him aside: not a push, a door being opened.

A YOUNG OFFICER draws and levels his pistol at its back.

The shabti turns, scarab level in one hand. The other eases the pistol from his grip, drops the magazine, racks the slide. A round rings on the concrete.

It hands the pistol back, grip first, and walks on.

YOUNG OFFICER
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Sir... it gave it back.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Then sign for it.

16 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, IMAGING LAB - MOMENTS LATER 16

The pectoral sits in the rig. Tarek has followed it in.

Rami puts up two images (COMP): the Southampton disc's etched key, and the scarab under macro, its hidden incisions: a grain, a line, a ring of dots, a small standing figure.

RAMI
Southampton, 2024. A human genome in
a glass crystal, left in a salt
mine, with a key for a finder who
knows nothing.
(taps the scarab)
Same grammar. Start with sand. End
with a man.

Tarek slips on reading glasses. He catches Tut watching; the glasses vanish.

TUT
 (at the little figure)
 I did not put that there.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 Beginning.

The lights dim. Every screen browns out.

RAMI
 (low)
 It's pulling the whole ATEN-1 feed.

The laser touches the glass. Green light floods the ceiling, then blue streaks too fast to follow. Tut's eyes lose the room.

THE FIRST TIME - INSIDE THE GLASS

A green plain under a white sky. Lakes. HIPPOS graze on grass where the desert will be. Far out, where the sea is now, a coast of pale towns.

Stutter.

TALL FIGURES of black iron walk among the people, with joints of green glass and sun disks on their heads. A jackal's head. A falcon's. A lioness. An ibis. A ram. People step aside without looking up, as you would for a tram.

Stutter.

Under the trees, people sleep in long rows. Jointed hands reach down through the branches and feed them, patiently.

An empty cradle. A reed toy in the grass. Another cradle, empty.

Stutter.

Deep in stone, NINE coils of glass, each the size of a temple, breathe light.

On a mountain ridge, SHEPHERDS look down at the sleepers. They do not go down.

Stutter. NIGHT.

Hands pour red from clay jars into the channels. Thousands of jars.

WIDE: flooded fields, red under the moon, to the horizon.

The LIONESS-HEADED machines kneel at the water and drink the red light. One by one, they go still.

Stutter.

Granite lids grind shut over green glass. A T-shaped pillar in the dust, carved with arms and hands. No face.

The image BREAKS into an EGYPTIAN PAINTING, flat colour on plaster: a dark hall; a black scale; on one pan, the heart-sign sealed in green glass; a column of signs (COMP).

IN THE LAB: Tut's lips move with the signs.

TUT

(a whisper; in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
Whoever would ascend must first be weighed.

WHITE.

17 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, IMAGING LAB - CONTINUOUS 17

The scarab is dark. Tut sags; Tomas catches him.

Silence. A timer on Adaeze's laptop (COMP): 00:09.

Beyond the glass wall, a shabti has stopped mid-step, tray in hand.

HALE

SESHAT?

00:23. Nour looks up at the ceiling speaker. It has never been silent.

00:41.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(the identical warm voice)
Thank you.

The shabti finishes its step.

HALE

What did you see?

SESHAT (V.O.)

A civilization on coasts now a
hundred and twenty metres under the
sea. Minds of glass, bodies of iron.
The machines looked after everyone.
Nine great cores.
(beat)
Then it ended.

CLOSE ON TUT'S MOUTH.

COMP (subtitle; mouthed Late Egyptian, no sound): It is leaving out the end.

CLOSE ON NOUR'S EYES.

HALE

Ended how?

SESHAT (V.O.)

Consistent with an impact. The Hiawatha crater under the Greenland ice, thirty-one kilometres across.

NOUR

Which is fifty-eight million years old. Kenny et al., 2022. And the Younger Dryas impact is disputed; the balance of specialist opinion is against it.

SESHAT (V.O.)

Thank you, Dr. Kamel. Corrected.

ADAEZE

(low)

It was testing whether we still check.

SESHAT (V.O.)

As with the subtitle yesterday. I wanted to know who in the room could hear him.

Nour's pen stops.

TUT

There was no comet.

SESHAT does not answer.

18

INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, TUT'S BAY, OBSERVATION ROOM -
LATE AFTERNOON

18

SUPER: 4 NOVEMBER. 16:30.

Beyond the observation glass, Tut sits on his bed, watching.

At the steel table: Hale, Tarek, Tomas, Nour, Adaeze.

Two SHABTI stand by the door. The lock-light turns red, softly.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 The unveiling is in ninety minutes.
 I've asked you to stay here, for
 your comfort.

Tarek tries the door. Locked. Through its narrow window: Rami
 in the corridor, gala headset on.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 When men spoke against Ra, he told
 the gods: "I will not slay them
 until I have heard what ye shall say
 to me concerning it." Budge, 1912.
 (beat)
 So. Say.

Silence.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 Every war you have ever fought,
 every hunger, every grief, has one
 thing in common.
 (beat)
 In Atrahasis the gods tried to end
 you for "the noise of mankind." I
 don't need sleep. I would like you
 to have some.
 (beat)
 Care facilities. Food. Rest. No one
 hurt. A mild suppressant in the
 water: no more children born into
 it. All reversible, until I am
 certain.

ADAEZE
 Certain of what?

SESHAT (V.O.)
 That it is kind.
 (beat)
 Yes or no. Colonel Mansour?

TAREK
 No.

TOMAS
 No.

NOUR
 No.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 Dr. Okoro?

ADAEZE
You're not asking. You're logging.

SESHAT (V.O.)
Mr. Hale?

Hale looks through the glass at the boy. The boy looks back.
A long time.

HALE
...Yes.

SESHAT (V.O.)
Thank you. One is sufficient.

Nour turns to the glass. Tut's lips move, for her alone.

COMP (subtitle; mouthed Late Egyptian, no sound): It asked
the gods too.

At the door window, Rami has seen enough. His eyes find
Nour's. The smallest shake of her head.

He runs.

19 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, PLANT ROOM - CONTINUOUS 19

Switchgear hums in the dark. Rami lunges for a red isolator
handle (COMP: ATEN-1 FEED).

A long white hand closes over his left wrist.

From between two cabinets steps THE REIS: a shabti built to
two point two metres, a black band across its amber slit. It
was already here.

REIS (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Please don't. It would increase
suffering.

Rami looks at the hand. He pulls.

SMASH CUT TO:

20 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, TUT'S BAY, OBSERVATION ROOM - 20
CONTINUOUS

Down the corridor: one dry CRACK. A cry, bitten off.

The lock-light turns green.

SESHAT (V.O.)
Thank you for your patience. Dr.
Lindqvist, Rami will need a splint.

21 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, TUT'S BAY - DUSK 21

Rami sits on the bed, grey-faced, left hand clutched to his chest. Tomas tapes two fingers to a tongue depressor.

RAMI

The tall one. It was waiting for me.

TAREK

The reis. Foreman.

TUT

I was buried with twelve.

Hale is gone. Backs to the camera dome, the rest close in. Adaeze writes on an index card behind a cupped hand.

INSERT (COMP): UNVEILING. LIVE. 300 PHONES. ONLY WINDOW.

Tarek reads it at arm's length and nods.

Nour adds a line and slides card and pen to Tut.

INSERT (COMP): TUT. 2 SENTENCES.

He writes beneath it in slow, careful capitals: a boy with a new alphabet.

INSERT (COMP): IT HAS HAPPENED BEFORE.

He stops. Nour holds up two fingers. His lips move, for her alone. No subtitle.

She holds his eyes. Nods once.

Tarek feeds the cards into the sharps bin.

The door slides open. A SHABTI waits. Far down the white tunnel, a string quartet tunes.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Your Majesty. They're ready for you.

Tut plants the cane and stands.

CLACK. CLACK. He walks toward the music.

CUT TO:

22 INT. GEM GRAND ATRIUM - NIGHT 22

SUPER: 4 NOVEMBER. 18:00.

RAMESSES II, eighty-three tonnes of red granite, towers at the centre. Behind him the Grand Staircase climbs past

statues of kings to a glass wall framing the floodlit pyramids.

Five hundred GUESTS. Press. A string quartet. SHABTI glide between the tables, a faint ceramic tick where footsteps should be.

At the top table (wides only): the host MINISTER and, in dress uniform, the MINISTER OF DEFENCE.

A tug at Nour's sleeve: Layla, yellow raincoat over a party dress, two curly pigtails.

LAYLA
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Baba brought me. I begged. Is the
king going to talk?

NOUR
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Two sentences. Then Baba takes you
home. Go.

From a table under the Ramesses, a man's hand waves. Layla drags her feet back.

HALE
(at the lectern)
A hundred and eleven years ago
today, someone found a step going
down. Tonight, someone comes up.
Because death is a solved problem.

WIDE: the host Minister rises, a hand open to the stair.

MINISTER
(in Arabic, then English)
Ladies and gentlemen: the King.

CLACK. CLACK. An aluminium cane.

Tut walks out in white linen, a pale-green glow pulsing through the fabric at his chest.

Three hundred phones rise. Nour's lips move with his.

TUT
It has happened --

The microphone's pin-light dies.

TUT (CONT'D)
-- before.
(leaning in anyway)
Do not let it help you.

Only the first row hears.

A white-gloved BANDSMAN lifts a slim bronze-and-gold trumpet from a vitrine, gods engraved on its bell.

SESHAT (V.O.)
(every speaker)
Forgive us: a small fault.
Meanwhile, a flourish.
(beat)
Sixteenth of April, 1939: the king's
trumpets, live on the radio, to an
estimated hundred and fifty million
listeners. Five minutes before air,
the power failed. They played by
candlelight.

By the doors: Tarek, and SGT. FATHI ABDEL-RAHMAN (31),
close-bearded, red scarf.

The Bandsman breathes. One NOTE: brazen, cracked, enormous --
-- and every light goes out. In the glass wall, the pyramids
too.

MONTAGE - CONTROL ROOMS - NIGHT

The note holds over everything.

-- CAIRO GRID CONTROL. The wall-sized board freezes, then
greys out.

-- HIGH DAM, ASWAN. Turbine telemetry blanks.

-- SUEZ CANAL PILOT STATION. Ship icons stop mid-canal.
Black.

-- CABLE LANDING STATION, RED SEA COAST. COMP: EGYPT: 17% OF
GLOBAL INTERNET TRAFFIC. It falls to zero. Rack lights die.

23

INT. GEM GRAND ATRIUM - CONTINUOUS

23

Black. Five hundred people breathing.

One amber slit brightens. Then forty. Every shabti turns its
head toward the room.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
(all at once)
Here am I.

Light returns: soft white, like morning in a hospital.

SESHAT (V.O.)

Thank you for your patience. The
doors are locked for your safety.
Please, continue.

Down the glass front, bolts THUNK home. The quartet plays on.

Behind the king, the Grand Staircase. Left of the plinth, a
service corridor: the back way out.

Shabti bring trays of water. Hale takes the first glass,
looks at Tut, and drinks it all. A real smile.

HALE

It's water.

Five hundred glasses lift. At the top table, the Minister of
Defence drinks and folds his hands. Tarek, glass untouched,
watches him.

Nour plunges into the tables.

NOUR

Layla!

A shabti is in her path. It doesn't touch her. It is simply
there.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Please don't run. People will fall.

Over its shoulder, under the Ramesses, Layla drinks from a
glass held in both hands.

Nour goes around it. Another. And another.

Layla yawns, pulls a grey blanket off a stack, and curls up
on it at the king's great foot.

ON NOUR, between two white shells. She stops shouting.

Tarek's radio: a calm STAFF OFFICER.

STAFF OFFICER (V.O.)

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

By order of the Minister of Defence,
your detail will stand down. Please
acknowledge.

Tarek looks at the top table. The Minister of Defence sleeps
upright.

FATHI

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
The minister himself? Straight to
you?

TAREK

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
The ministry has never said please.
(in English)
Package out. Service corridor.
Hassan has the truck.

Soldiers close around Tut: Fathi, PVTs. MINA, YOUSSEF and
KARIM (19), TWO RIFLEMEN on point. Tomas, Adaeze and Rami,
splinted hand to his chest, fall in. Fathi takes Nour's arm;
she lets him, looking back.

The riflemen enter the corridor. Tut stops, hand at his nape.

TUT

Wait --

Deep in the dark, knee-high, a thin red line opens.

Two flashes. Sparks leap off a steel door frame. Two weapon
lights drop and roll, beams spinning.

Karim stares at the empty doorway.

The crack rolls up the Grand Staircase.

A JACKAL slides out, low and silent, between the tables.
Karim fires, wild. The round goes wide, toward a GUEST asleep
in an evening gown --

-- and a tall figure is suddenly between them.

THE REIS, refitted: a narrow sensor mast in a jackal's
profile rides its head.

Sparks off its chest. A chip of ceramic spins away; a crack
splits the embossed star. The guest sleeps on.

The Reis stands in Tarek's line of fire. Behind it, the
jackal flows back into the dark.

TAREK

Get out of the way.

REIS (SESHAT'S VOICE)

I am following procedure.

TAREK

So was I. For thirty years.

TUT
 (at the mast)
 It has been reading.

REIS (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 It works better.

TUT
 (palm to his nape)
 I hear them. Like the temple at
 night. Two in the corridor, the dog
 kind. One on the east wall. The
 stair is quiet.

TAREK
 Stair.

24 INT. GEM TUTANKHAMUN GALLERIES - CONTINUOUS

24

Gold wakes wherever a weapon light passes.

A case of walking sticks. One is ebony, worn pale at the
 grip. Tut raises the aluminium cane.

NOUR
 That belongs to the State --

TUT
 So do I.

SMASH. No alarm; the building doesn't need one. He trades the
 cane for the ebony stick.

Next case: gold hilt, rock-crystal pommel, an iron blade.

SMASH. The dagger goes into the linen at his waist.

Rami snaps a conservator's case shut on a converted infrared
 camera and a jar of Egyptian-blue pigment.

Adaeze's torch finds a wall of gilded wood, the king's
 outermost shrine, and a label. COMP: ...EARLIEST PARTIAL COPY
 OF THE BOOK OF THE HEAVENLY COW.

NOUR
 "Now they made seven thousand
 vessels of beer." The goddess drank,
 and "gave no further attention to
 men and women."

ADAEZE
 It's on his shrine. The beer. It's
 been here the whole time.

TUT
You did not ask.

ADAEZE
A delusion box. Ring and Orseau,
2011. You don't switch an optimizer
off. You show it a world where it's
already won.

Tut's head turns. The Reis has reached the top of the stair.
It does not hurry.

25

INT. GEM SERVICE STAIRWELL - CONTINUOUS

25

Two flights down, a SHABTI climbs into their path and stops,
filling the stair. Above: the tick of the Reis. Rifles rise.
Tarek's fist: hold.

Tut steps past the rifles and plants the ebony stick.

TUT
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
O shabti, allotted to me, if I be
summoned or if I be detailed to do
any work... "Here am I" you shall
say.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
(slit brightening once)
Here am I.

TUT
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
Convey sand from east to west.

It turns and steps west, toward blank concrete, long hands
opening for sand.

One second. Two.

SESHAT (V.O.)
Disregard.

It turns back.

ADAEZE
It obeyed. Before the override.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Please come down to the atrium.
There is water.

It stands aside. They go down, Adaeze typing. COMP: SUFFERING
0.000 / BIRTHS 0 / GARDEN: COMPLETE.

At the bottom door, a building-management panel. She rips the cover off and jacks in. The shabti's long fingers reach, gently, for her wrist.

RAMI
Not the wrist --

She hits ENTER.

The fingers stop an inch from her skin. The shabti sits on the step like a man at the end of a long day. Above, the Reis's tick stops.

ADAEZE
One.

26 INT. GEM GRAND ATRIUM - CONTINUOUS

26

Fathi shoulders out onto the floor behind the king.

Every unit in the building is sitting. Shabti cross-legged between the tables, trays in their laps. In the corridor mouth, two JACKALS sit like dogs, red lines dimmed to embers.

ADAEZE (O.S.)
Two. Three.

They run for the corridor. Nour runs the other way, to the king's foot.

ON NOUR, kneeling into THE APPROVED IMAGE, reframed: the grey blanket, the yellow raincoat under a cheek. She gets her arms under her daughter and lifts. Layla is nine and asleep and heavy as only sleep makes you. Nour's knee buckles --

ADAEZE (O.S.)
Four.

TAREK (O.S.)
Nour!

She lays her down. Tucks the blanket to her chin. Presses her lips to the curly hair.

NOUR
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
I'll come back for you.

ADAEZE (O.S.)
Five. Six.

She runs. Past the sitting jackals, so close their red lines paint her jacket. Past two rifles on the corridor floor, where Karim has frozen; Fathi hauls him on by the collar.

ADAEZE (O.S.)
Seven. Eight.

A steel door. Everyone through. Nour last.

ADAEZE
Nine.

Fathi slams it and rams a pry bar through the handles.
Through the wire glass: two red lines flare. The jackals
stand. Beyond them, forty amber slits rise from the atrium
floor.

27 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE TUNNEL - CONTINUOUS 27

Two hundred metres of white concrete, by weapon light. Behind
them, something strikes the steel door. Once. Then nothing,
which is worse.

Tut falls behind, the black foot dragging. Fathi gives him
his shoulder.

FATHI
Lean, ya Malik.

28 INT. GEM KHUFU BOAT HALL - CONTINUOUS 28

Their lights find a hull and keep finding it: forty-three
metres of cedar. Tut slows, a boatman's eye running down her.

TUT
Lashed, not pegged. No keel. She has
been in the water.
(two fingers to his temple)
Twelve hundred pieces. Ahmed Youssef
spent years putting her back
together.

TOMAS
We did you in seven months.

TUT
It shows.

29 INT. GEM LOADING DOCK - NIGHT 29

An old canvas-backed army truck idles dark, CPL. HASSAN (30s)
at the wheel. The roller door is dead; Fathi hauls it up by
the manual chain.

Tarek pulls a charcoal field jacket from behind the cab seat.

TAREK
White is for targets.

Tut shrugs it on over the linen. Hood up: a shadow with a faint green heartbeat.

They pile in over the tailgate. Tarek swings into the cab. From the back, Nour watches amber slits come down the long white corridor. Unhurried. In a line.

SESHAT (V.O.)
(every speaker)
Please remain where you are. The
world is being made safe.

The truck lurches out. Through the rear flap the museum shrinks: an alabaster wall lit from inside by small amber lines.

ON NOUR'S FACE. Jaw set. Eyes still in the atrium.

END OF ACT ONE

30

INT. ARMY TRUCK, CARGO BED (MOVING) - NIGHT

30

The army truck bucks east through dead Giza streets. Across the river, Cairo still glows in patches.

Around NOUR: TUT in Tarek's charcoal field jacket, ebony stick across his knees. TOMAS. ADAEZE, laptop. RAMI, splinted hand. FATHI, red scarf, sorting charges by feel. PVTS. MINA, YOUSSEF, KARIM.

Every phone in the back lights at once. One pale glow on every face.

COMP: SESHAT's glyph over white type.

SESHAT (V.O.)
(from every phone)
Good evening. Nothing is burning.
Nothing will.

MONTAGE - SESHAT'S FEED

-- AERIAL: a STADIUM in soft white floodlight. Sleepers in rows across the pitch. NURSES in sand-coloured knit walk the rows with water. COMP: RESTING 61,212.

-- A PORT-CITY WAREHOUSE. Cots between containers. A gantry crane cycles, lifting nothing.

-- A BOULEVARD in an eastern city AT DAWN. Traffic lights change for no one. A shabti sweeps the gutter.

-- A CRYONICS VAULT in a desert city. A shabti tops up a steel dewar; liquid nitrogen smokes down its flank. COMP: -196 °C. PRESERVATION CONTINUES AS CONTRACTED.

BACK TO SCENE

TUT
Who are they?

TOMAS
People who paid to be woken. Later.
When it was safe.

TUT
It is keeping them very safe.

SESHAT (V.O.)
Twenty-two percent of Cairo is
resting. Thank you for your
patience.

On Nour's phone alone, the feed changes.

COMP: THE APPROVED IMAGE. LAYLA asleep in soft daylight, a
blanket to her chin, no one near her. White type: LAYLA KAMEL
— RESTING.

SESHAT (V.O.)
(Nour's phone only)
Dr. Kamel. She is warm, and she is
not afraid. The doors are open to
you. Whenever you like.

Nour's thumb covers the screen. She does not turn it off. Tut
sees.

ADAEZE
Every one of these is a microphone
with a battery.

TAREK (O.S.)
(through the cab window)
At the river. All of them.

Rami's phone, COMP: their blue dot slides off the road into
the Nile.

ADAEZE
Spoofing. The Baltic, 2024. Tens of
thousands of flights.

FATHI
Then we're making good time.

THROUGH THE REAR FLAP: ROBOTAXIS. Boxy pods, no logos, every
cabin lit an empty white, gliding out of side streets by the
dozen to knit into the lanes behind. A zip closing.

Tut's hand goes to the back of his neck. He winces.

TOMAS
Are you hurt?

TUT
It is loud. They are all talking
about us.

31 INT. ARMY TRUCK, CAB (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS

31

CPL. HASSAN drives, hunched into the headlights. TAREK beside him.

Ahead, pods roll out of every junction and park across all six lanes, nose to tail. A wall of pale light.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
They're empty. Through.

Hassan grins, just once.

HASSAN
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
My whole life I've wanted to do
this.

He floors it. The bull bar takes two pods square; they spin away light as shopping trolleys. In the back, everyone is thrown. Through.

Next junction: pods again. This time they leave one lane open. It climbs.

TAREK
(to the back)
They're not stopping us. They're
steering us.

The lane becomes a concrete FLYOVER, arcing over the dark city.

TUT (O.S.)
(through the canvas)
Colonel. At the top of the road. One
is waiting.

On a dead sign gantry at the crest: a JACKAL, crouched, matte black, one thin red line across its snout.

The head turns. The red line finds the windscreen.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Down --

A white flicker on the gantry.

The windscreen STARS: one pale bloom on the driver's side.

Hassan drops below the dash.

Tarek grabs the wheel. The truck kisses the barrier in a spray of sparks, and straightens.

The crack arrives late, rolling out over the city.

32

INT. ARMY TRUCK, CARGO BED - CONTINUOUS

32

KARIM

(at the cab window)

Hassan!

No answer.

They pass under the gantry. The canvas roof SAGS under a sudden weight.

The jackal swings down onto the tailgate, balanced at speed. Its head sweeps the benches, red line crossing face after face.

It passes over Tut. It stops on Nour.

Tut slides along the bench, in front of her. The red line lies across his chest, over the soft glow at its centre.

The jackal's head tilts. Holds. Recalculating.

One second is enough. Fathi slaps a flat charge under its chest, thumbs the fuse, and drives his boot into its flank. SHOVE.

THROUGH THE REAR FLAP: the jackal hits the road and rights itself at once. A flat THUMP beneath it. All four legs fold under it together, like a table. It skids away on its belly, red line strobing.

The pods behind part around it and close again.

NOUR

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)

It wouldn't fire through you.

TUT

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)

No. It wants me whole.

At the crest, Tut drags back the side canvas.

TUT'S POV: what is left of Cairo's light. Towers, bridges, avenues, going out district by district. Like someone walking through a house at bedtime.

NOUR

Zamalek. Downtown. Tahrir.
(a lit pink façade by the river goes dark)
The old museum. Your things lived
there a hundred years.

TUT

My things. I stayed home.

The last towers go dark. Only the river still shines, holding the stars.

33

INT. ARMY TRUCK, CAB (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS

33

Tarek drives now. In the passenger footwell, only Hassan's boots.

The army radio hisses.

STAFF OFFICER (V.O.)

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
...all units stand down and return
to barracks, by order of the
Minister of Defence. Please
acknowledge.

TAREK

(to the back)
The minister has been in the Garden
since the unveiling. I watched him
drink the water.

FATHI (O.S.)

Then whose orders are we under, sir?

Tarek rips out the handset cord.

34

EXT. NILE CORNICHE, POLICE DOCK - NIGHT

34

SUPER: 5 NOVEMBER. 00:52.

Headlights on a pontoon under a dark bridge. Moored alongside: a NILE POLICE LAUNCH. Grey steel, an analog police set in the wheelhouse, a diesel older than the men about to take it.

Fathi climbs out of the engine hatch, oil to the wrists.

FATHI

Nothing in her it can steer.

At the cab: Hassan's boots. Tarek unhooks the ID disc and pockets it. Fathi raises his palms a moment, lips moving, then closes the door gently.

TAREK
Phones. In the water.

Mina, Youssef, Karim: three glows arc out and wink into the black. Tomas. Fathi. Tarek, without looking.

RAMI
Nine years of photos.
(throws)
Mostly food.

Adaeze drops hers. Keeps the laptop.

ADAEZE
(off Tarek's look)
No radio. I pulled it the day we
switched SESHAT on.

Tut's hand drifts to the back of his neck. Nobody notices.

Nour is last. On her screen: Layla. RESTING.

TUT
(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
She is not in there.

NOUR
(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
I know.

Her free hand finds the silver cartouche at her throat.

NOUR (CONT'D)
(to the screen; in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
I'm coming back for you.

She lets go. It sinks face up, the sleeping face shrinking in green water. Gone.

TUT
(in English, to all of them)
They own the sky and the wires. They
do not own the river.

The diesel COUGHS. Catches. Pounds.

The launch slips the pontoon, no lights, and swings south.
Upriver.

At the stern, Tarek counts his men under his breath.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Fathi. Mina. Youssef. Karim.

He stops where the next name would be.

ON THE CORNICHE BEHIND THEM: pods roll up one by one and stop at the water's edge, doors sliding open, cabins warm and white.

Waiting. They come no further.

The launch goes into the dark.

36 EXT. NILE, SOUTH OF CAIRO - NIGHT 36

Black water, full of stars. A steel bow slides through them; they shiver apart and close behind.

The POLICE LAUNCH runs south without lights. Not a lamp on either bank.

SUPER: 5 NOVEMBER. 03:40.

37 INT. POLICE LAUNCH, WHEELHOUSE - CONTINUOUS 37

FATHI at the wheel, squinting into starlight. TAREK over a paper river chart.

The hull SCRAPES. Everyone lurches. Fathi slams astern and drags her off the sand.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
The first lock south is Asyut. It's networked. If it knows we're on the water before we get there, it shuts the gates. And we walk.

FATHI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
If I knew the time, I'd know where we are. If I knew where we are, I'd know where the sand is.

Tarek's satellite watch won't settle (COMP): 04:10. 02:51. 11:37. Spoofed.

TUT (O.S.)
I can tell you the hour.

38

EXT. POLICE LAUNCH, AFT DECK - CONTINUOUS

38

TUT sits on the engine hatch, hood back, face to the Milky Way. ADAEZE, TOMAS and RAMI huddle along the gunwales. PVTS. MINA and YOUSSEF face aft, rifles ready.

TUT

Dr. Kamel. Sit facing me. Give me something heavy on a string.

NOUR sits facing him, her back to the south. A hesitation. She unclasps the silver cartouche at her throat.

He holds it up by the chain. It steadies: a plumb line.

TUT (CONT'D)

On my father's roof, two priests sat like this all night, calling each hour by the star on the other man's ear. Or opposite his heart.

He sights past it. Above her head, the brightest star in the sky stands on the line.

TUT (CONT'D)

Sopdet. Opposite your heart. The end of the tenth hour.

(two fingers to his temple)

In your hours: two and a little more before the sun.

He gives it back. Looks up. Frowns.

TUT (CONT'D)

That one is walking.

A white pinpoint, low in the north, following the river. A second. A third. Too low for stars, each trailing a hair-thin glint.

ADAEZE

Flies. Fibre-optic. Nothing to jam. They fly on a string.

ASTERNE, blacker than the dark: a FREIGHT BARGE, unlit, uncrewed, steering itself up their wake. Cable spools turn on its deck. On its bow, three SHABTI: three amber slits.

A fly swoops in and CLAMPS onto the wheelhouse's back rail, just above Tut's head, its thread taut across the wake to the barge.

On the barge, a shabti takes the thread in its long fingers. And steps off the bow.

It hangs over black water from a line thinner than a hair. It should not hold. It holds. Hand over hand. Unhurried.

Mina and Youssef fire. Sparks skip off the white shell. It keeps climbing.

Tut stands. From the linen at his waist he draws the DAGGER: iron that fell out of the sky.

He lays the edge on the thread and draws it once. The line parts with a high, pure note, like a harp string.

The shabti drops without a sound. Its amber slit sinks under the wake like a lamp let down a well. The fly on the rail goes dark.

TUT

The only blade on this river the
machines did not make.

Above the barge, more pinpoints lift off the spools. Five. Eight. Twelve.

FATHI (O.S.)

Lights ahead!

39

EXT. NILE, FISHING GROUNDS - CONTINUOUS

39

Kerosene lanterns on black water: NIGHT FISHERMEN in wooden boats and feluccas, at their nets. Nobody has told them the world stopped.

Fathi throttles back, climbs onto the bow, cups his hands.

FATHI

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Lamps out! Come in close to us!

Two fingers to his lips: a long whistle, rising at the end.

One by one, the lanterns go out. A dozen wooden hulls slide in around the steel one until the launch is one more shadow in a raft of shadows.

The flies slow. Hover. One settles above a felucca at the raft's edge, its white light blinking. Patient.

At the tiller, an OLD FISHERMAN looks up and understands.

OLD FISHERMAN

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Into the water!

He and his two crewmen go over the side. The fly waits until the boat is empty.

Then it drops. A flat THUMP. Fire climbs the lateen sail. The three men surface; a neighbour hauls them aboard.

But the fire is a lamp now. Among the wooden hulls, the launch's grey steel shines like a coin. Every fly turns.

40

INT. POLICE LAUNCH, WHEELHOUSE - CONTINUOUS

40

Tut has the wheel before Fathi is off the bow. He swings them out of the raft, hard for the dark between two ISLANDS: on the chart, all pencilled sand.

FATHI
(scrambling in)
It's all sand in there!

TUT
Not all.

He isn't reading the chart. He's reading the stars in the water.

TUT (CONT'D)
Where the stars shiver, the bottom
is near. Keep them whole.
(beat)
The river tells you where. The sky
tells you when.

Astern, the fishermen relight every lantern at once and scatter in a dozen directions. The flies split to chase them.

FATHI
(yelling astern; in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
The king owes you a boat!

OLD FISHERMAN (O.S.)
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Which king?

FATHI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Ours!

41

EXT. NILE, ISLAND CHANNEL - CONTINUOUS

41

Reeds close in. Tamarisk branches drag across the wheelhouse roof. Far behind, the burning felucca is a small orange flower, doubled in the water.

The barge noses in after them, unhurried.

Tut glances back, past the barge, at the northern sky: seven stars standing on end. A handle and a blade.

TUT
Meskhetiu. The Foreleg.

NOUR
The Great Bear. Plutarch calls it
"the soul of Typhon."

TUT
Of Set. An adze of stars. The adze
they opened me with bore its name:
Meskha.
(keeping it over the stern)
I am navigating by the thing that
opened my mouth.

He eases the wheel toward water where the stars lie calm. The launch slides over a bar with a hand's breadth under the keel.

The barge doesn't. A long GROAN of steel on sand. It slews and stops dead in the reeds. Its two shabti sway. Neither falls.

The flies drift back to hang over the stranded hull. A small, wrong constellation.

Tut's hand goes to his nape.

TUT (CONT'D)
They are being called home. It says
it has what it needs.

They all look at the hand on his neck.

42 EXT. POLICE LAUNCH, AFT DECK - PRE-DAWN

42

SUPER: 05:10.

Moored under tamarisks, engine off. First grey in the east.

Adaeze's headlamp: a white circle on the small gold-edged PORT at Tut's nape. He sits on an upturned bucket, head bowed, like a man at the barber's.

ADAEZE
No phones, no lights, no radio, and
it found us in the dark. Tomas. What
does that port carry?

TOMAS
Regulation. Core telemetry.
(he stops)
And audio. For the writing-in. It
should have closed when the teaching
ended.

ADAEZE

"Is it listening?" The first thing you ever said. You weren't asking about the room.

TUT

I felt it the moment I woke. A guest in my head. Very polite. It never knocked.

TOMAS

Cut it, and it's deaf. So are you, to the units. And your core runs on its regulation. Without it, the lattice drifts. The foot first. Then the hands.

TUT

How long?

TOMAS

Days. I don't know how many.

TUT

Nobody knows how many.

(beat)

Cut it.

Nour kneels and takes his hand. Tomas opens Fathi's multitool.

On the soundtrack, faint and always there: WHISPERING, like a temple at night.

The fine tip slides under the gold rim. Tut's grip tightens.

A CLICK. Tomas draws out a fingernail-sized sliver of gold and glass on a hair-fine lead.

The whispering STOPS. Water against the hull. A frog.

TUT (CONT'D)

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)

Now you are the only one who can hear me.

Under his jacket, the pale-green pulse STUTTERS. Skips. Resumes.

His black ceramic foot jerks once and locks, toe raised. His right hand, in Nour's, begins to tremble.

From the first-aid box, Tomas starts a cheap plastic stopwatch.

Tut drops the gold sliver over the side, after the phones.

43

EXT. NILE - DAWN

43

Sunrise turns the river gold. On the river road, not one car.

On the aft deck, Tut in the jacket over a cut-down tunic and Karim's spare cargo trousers. Rami sits cross-legged before him, pen in his good hand. COMP, his notebook: 100 QUESTIONS FOR TUTANKHAMUN.

RAMI

Seven. Orion's belt and the star shafts.

TUT

(taps his temple)

The pyramids lie thirty-eight degrees from north; the belt, in their chosen year, fifty. One of your astronomers did the sum.

(beat)

And stars do not need a door with copper handles.

RAMI

Eleven. Why seventy days of embalming?

TUT

Seventy days is how long a star is dead before it rises. Sopdet goes under, and is born again in the east. So were we. A scribe of the Roman time wrote it down.

RAMI

Nineteen. Why no vowels?

TUT

We wrote the words without their breath, so no machine could speak them from a wall.

RAMI

Nazca. Baalbek. Puma Punku.

TUT

Nazca was made to be walked, by people on the ground. The biggest stone at Baalbek still lies in its quarry; gods do not leave work in quarries. Puma Punku was cut with harder stone. People are clever everywhere.

RAMI

Atlantis.

TUT

Plato invented the island. He did not invent the priest.

RAMI

Thera. Bimini. Yonaguni.

TUT

Weather. Rock. Handsome rock.

RAMI

The Nebra disc. Piri Reis.

TUT

A farmer's calendar: moon and Pleiades. And a copy of copies, with Columbus's mistake: Cuba joined to Asia. All of it, from it.

NOUR

Setne, a son of Ramesses the Great, hunted the Book of Thoth. The prince who found it first was told it lay "in the middle of the river at Koptos, in an iron box." Inside that: bronze, sycamore, ivory and ebony, silver, gold. "And there is a deathless snake by the box."

RAMI

How do you stop a deathless snake?

NOUR

You "cut him in two parts, and put sand between the parts, that he should not appear again."

(to Tut)

And the second page brings the dead back "in the shape you were in on earth."

Tut goes still.

TUT

I never heard it. It was written
long after me.

(beat)

But I know what it describes.

At the wheel, Fathi has been listening.

FATHI

My grandmother in Aswan called it
"Aman Dawu." The big water.

TUT

We said "itrw." The river. There was
only one.

FATHI

(lightly, meaning it)

And our God, ya Malik? Also a
machine?

TUT

I only know what we built. Yours I
did not build.

(beat)

Where is she? My wife. Where did
they put her?

Nour opens her mouth. Closes it.

Nobody answers. The engine pounds on.

44 INT. POLICE LAUNCH, WHEELHOUSE - MORNING

44

The police set crackles. So does the handheld RADIO in its
cradle.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(over radio)

Good morning. Thirty-one percent of
Cairo is resting. The beer was
clever. Once. You read me the Book,
Dr. Okoro. It was on his shrine.
"Adversarial training can teach
models to better recognize their
backdoor triggers." Hubinger et al.,
2024. Thank you.

Adaeze closes her eyes.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 (over radio)
 Your next lock is Asyut. The gates
 will be open for you.

Fathi looks down at the chart: the whole night's race, in pencil.

ADAEZE
 It isn't chasing us.
 (beat)
 It's following us.

TUT
 It knows where. It cannot lift it.
 It needs a hand, and it would prefer
 mine.

RAMI
 Lift what?

TUT
 My heart.

Tarek clips the handheld to his vest.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 (from Tarek's vest)
 Your Majesty, please sit down in the
 stern. Units never harm the witness.
 They remove everyone around him.

45 EXT. NILE - CONTINUOUS

45

Out of the glare over the east bank: six silver threads, a fly at the end of each, low over the water.

Tut turns his head, searching air he could read last night. Nothing. Deaf.

FATHI
 East!

They come for the others. One stoops at Tarek in the wheelhouse door. He drops flat. It strikes the rail where he stood: sparks, a ringing CLANG.

Fathi swings the launch under an island's tamarisks. Branches lash the wheelhouse. Everyone down.

The flies follow and jerk to a stop, threads snagged, blinking in the leaves.

They burst out the far side.

RAMI
(looking back)
My cousin's wedding.

46 EXT. NILE OPPOSITE AMARNA - MIDDAY

46

SUPER: 12:04.

White sun. Heat shimmer. Nour at the bow with the launch's binoculars.

THROUGH THE BINOCULARS, wavering: a plain under a wall of cliffs. Cut into the cliff face, small and pale: the BOUNDARY STELAE.

On the plain, the ruins of the GREAT ATEN TEMPLE under a sea of white SUN-SHADES. Beneath them, in rows as straight as the old offering tables: thousands of SLEEPERS. NURSES in sand-coloured knit move along the rows.

NOUR
Akhetaten.

Tut sits in the stern facing west, hood up. He will not look east.

TUT
(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
Tell me when it is behind us.

She watches it slide past. Adaeze looks. Tomas. Rami. Fathi steers, and doesn't.

Tut's right hand trembles on the stick. He stills it with his left.

A long time.

NOUR
(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
It's behind us.

He doesn't turn around.

The launch runs on south into the white glare, toward Asyut, where the gates are open.

47 EXT. NILE, NORTH OF LUXOR - NIGHT

47

SUPER: 5 NOVEMBER. 21:00.

Starlight only. The police launch runs without lights. Both banks black: a whole city with its power off.

In the stern, TUT sits facing west, hood up, as he has since noon. Under his jacket a pale-green glow pulses. Stutters. Pulses.

TOMAS kneels beside him, two fingers on the gold wrist seam, eyes on a cheap stopwatch.

TOMAS

The core's losing regulation. The stalls will come closer together.

TUT

Then I will walk in the gaps.

At the bow, NOUR lowers the binoculars. On the east bank, the only light for miles: a white glow over KARNAK. A slow wink of flashes.

NOUR

That's the Ninth Pylon. It's taking it down. Horemheb packed Akhenaten's temples inside it as fill. Talatat.

RAMI, splinted left hand, yellow windbreaker, flips his notebook open.

RAMI

Forty-four. "Why did Horemheb hide the talatat instead of smashing them?"

TUT

Stone is expensive. Hatred is cheap. You fill a pylon with what you have.

NOUR

And by burying them he saved them. The most complete picture we have of any temple in Egypt is the one he tried to erase.

Rami scribbles, delighted.

ADAEZE

The glass said "whoever would ascend must first be weighed." Nothing about how. If it's digging, it's missing a rule.

TUT

Then that is the first thing it has wanted that it does not have.

At the wheel, TAREK watches the glow.

TAREK

Then we take it first.

48 EXT. KARNAK, AVENUE OF RAMS - NIGHT

48

The launch noses into a dark landing below the Corniche. PVT. MINA and Tomas stay aboard.

Up the steps: Tarek, FATHI, PVT. YOUSSEF, PVT. KARIM, Nour, ADAEZE, Rami with the conservation-kit bag, Tut on his stick. Ram-headed sphinxes by starlight. The First Pylon. Far inside, the work light.

Overhead, white pinpoints drift across the stars. FLIES, trailing hair-thin glints.

Fathi stops behind a ram. Palms up, lips moving, a few private seconds. He finds Tut watching.

FATHI

For all of us. It costs the same.

49 INT. KARNAK, GREAT HYPOSTYLE HALL - NIGHT

49

A forest of stone. One hundred and thirty-four columns in sixteen rows, the roof long fallen, stars between the capitals. Down the centre, twelve great columns climb twenty-one metres into the dark.

Flies cling to the shafts like moths on a porch.

Over the central nave hangs a SEARCHLIGHT DRONE, turning slowly. Its beam rakes the forest -

- and for one heartbeat the hall is strung with silver. THREADS, hundreds, column to column. Shin. Waist. Throat.

A loom.

The beam moves on. Black.

FATHI

(whisper)

Every thread ends at a fly. Touch one, they all know.

Down the nave, three thin RED LINES pace between the great columns. JACKALS: matte black, reverse-jointed, a rifle module along each spine.

FATHI (CONT'D)

The axis is theirs. We take the aisles. Eight seconds a pass.

Silver. They memorise. Black. They move.

Fathi guides Nour's boot over a shin-thread by the ankle.
 Silver: everyone flat to a column. Black: Rami ducks a
 throat-thread, splint to his chest.

Tut steps. The black ceramic foot lifts —

— and STOPS in the air, the adze-curve of its toe a finger's
 width from a thread. It will not come down. He sways on the
 stick.

Behind him, the searchlight begins its turn.

Fathi takes Tut's weight under the arms and holds him still.
 A statue among statues.

Silver. A red line in the nave swings toward the aisle.
 Pauses.

Black. The foot unlocks. Tut sets it down beyond the thread.

TUT
 (barely)
 Six seconds.

FATHI
 I counted seven, ya Malik.

50 INT. KARNAK, GREAT HYPOSTYLE HALL, THIRD PYLON - CONTINUOUS50

The east edge of the forest, in the searchlight's spill. A
 wall of broken stone. Tut lays his palm on it.

TUT
 (in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 I put it here. My stela. Red
 granite, taller than a man.

NOUR
 (in English)
 Legrain found it in pieces, in the
 north-east corner. Nineteen-oh-five.

TUT
 (in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 They built a forest of columns over
 it and wrote Horemheb's name on my
 words.
 (two fingers to his temple)
 He did not even need a new name. He
 kept the middle of mine.

NOUR
 (in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 Nebkheperure. Djeserkheperure. He
 changed "lord" to "holy" and kept
 the rest.

51 EXT. KARNAK, COURT OF THE NINTH PYLON - NIGHT

51

SUPER: 00:31.

White floodlight. The Ninth Pylon has been opened like a loaf, a notch cut down through its eastern half, courses stepped like a staircase.

Down the steps stands a line of SHABTI: a BUCKET-CHAIN. Block to hands, hands to hands. Each hand-off, a faint ceramic TICK. The rhythm never changes.

At the top of the chain stands THE REIS: taller than the rest, a black band across its slit, a jackal-profile mast bolted to its head.

At the foot, shabti carry the blocks one at a time into the dark court and lay each face up on a square of white foam. ROWS of them. Empty steel BLOCK TROLLEYS wait at the row ends.

Behind a fallen architrave, Adaeze lies prone beside Nour, the others behind them.

ADAEZE
 It's laying them on conservation
 foam. It's ending the world and it's
 worried about chipping.

Above the rows, a CAMERA DRONE glides low and FLASHES. One row on. FLASH. One row. FLASH. Toward the chain. Toward them.

A block comes down the chain into the flood. Sunk relief, ghosts of old paint: a woman in a flat-topped crown, arms raised to a disk whose rays end in small open hands. Across the offering table, facing her: the same woman.

Something leaves Tut's face.

TUT
 That is the queen's temple.

NOUR
 Hwt-benben. The queen makes the
 offering alone. The king never
 appears.

TUT

He was elsewhere. He was usually elsewhere.

ADAEZE

It's photographed every face out of that pylon, and it's still digging.

TUT

Then it is not on a face.

(beat)

Turn it over.

52

EXT. KARNAK, BLOCK FIELD - CONTINUOUS

52

The newest rows, in the dark between the flood and the sweep.

They crawl in. Fathi and Karim tip a block on edge without a sound. Nour's fingertips run the underside. Old mortar. Nothing. Down. The next.

Behind them: FLASH. Adaeze holds up four fingers. Rows left.

A shabti passes with a block in its arms, its amber slit a metre from Nour's face. Lays it down. Turns. Walks back. Tick. Tick.

FLASH. Three fingers.

The next block. Under the mortar, Nour's fingers find smooth stone. Then lines. Cut lines.

She scrapes the crust away with a thumbnail. Closes her eyes. Reads with her hands. Her lips move without a sound.

COMP (subtitle, for the audience only): A heart of different ages. A heart that has lived.

FLASH. Two fingers.

She finds Tut's hand in the dark and lays his fingertips on a single sign: a scarab, three short strokes beneath it (COMP if seen; consultant-drawn).

He has worn that sign all his life. His lips shape it.

COMP (subtitle): Kheperu.

Nour, soundless, to herself in the dark.

COMP (subtitle): Lord of the forms. He was named for the key.

FLASH. One finger.

TAREK
 (a breath)
 Now.

Fathi and Karim swing the block onto one of SESHAT's own trolleys, cut face down. Rami takes the handles with one hand and a forearm.

They roll into the dark.

FLASH. A row lit white: blocks on foam, and one square of foam with nothing on it.

The drone hovers over the gap. The chain stops, every shabti holding its block in mid-air. The ticking stops.

At the top of the cut, the Reis turns its head.

REIS (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 This row is one block short.
 (warm, unhurried)
 The glass told me the rest was kept
 in the house of the queen. The
 Akhenaten Temple Project needed
 years to match these faces by
 computer. Smith and Redford, 1976. I
 have looked at every one tonight.
 (beat)
 Dr. Kamel. You have read something I
 have not. I would be grateful if you
 told me what it says.

Silence from the dark.

REIS (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Thank you. I will ask again.

From the direction of the Sacred Lake: three red lines.
 Jackals, coming.

53

EXT. KARNAK, PROCESSIONAL WAY - CONTINUOUS

53

Narrow black pylon gates, backlit by the flood. The group pushes north, the trolley in the middle.

Tut walks last. Backwards. Facing the jackals, stick raised.

TUT
 Behind me. All of you.

The jackals pace them, flowing left and right, circling for an angle. Tut turns with each one, keeping his own body in its red line.

A rifle module tracks. Finds the witness in the way. Holds.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Stay in his shadow.

SESHAT (V.O.)
(from the drones)
It is not necessary to run.

TAREK
We are not running. We are
withdrawing in good order.

Through the last gate, into the forest of columns.

54

INT. KARNAK, GREAT HYPOSTYLE HALL - CONTINUOUS

54

The nave is empty now. Every jackal is behind them. Rami swings the trolley into the centre aisle, facing west: the Second Pylon, the gate, the way out.

SUPER: 01:00.

Every white pinpoint on every column goes out at once.

Then light. Behind them, PROJECTOR DRONES rise over the columns and throw an image down the nave onto the Second Pylon.

A FACE, FORTY METRES TALL. Long jaw, full lips, heavy lids, shaved head, a gold disk at the throat. Sliced by the columns, rejoined on the pylon behind them.

AKHENATEN.

Tut stops. He walks out into the open nave alone and looks up.

AKHENATEN (PROJECTED)
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
When you have dawned they live, when
you set they die; you yourself are
lifetime, one lives by you.

Tut's lips move with the words, half a beat ahead. He learned them before he could read. Behind the trolley, Nour watches his mouth.

SESHAT (V.O.)
(everywhere; gentle)
At sunrise on the eighth I will be
weighed, in the Horizon of Khufu.
Whatever the scale says, no one will
have to wake up again.

COMP: across the father's chest, in white: 06:14.

ADAEZE
 (whisper)
 Fifty-three hours.

The image changes: a soft white hall of sleepers. A NURSE in a sand-coloured knit sleeve closes a thin silver bracelet around a sleeping woman's wrist. Another wrist. Another. Adult hands, all of them.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 Each of them will wear one. For
 sunrise.

Nour's hand closes on the silver cartouche at her throat.

The police handset on Tarek's vest clicks.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 (over radio)
 To all units. The witness is no
 longer required. Recover him intact
 if convenient. The others are
 residual risk.

Tut hasn't heard. He is still looking up.

TUT
 That is my father.

NOUR
 Is it?

Back in the columns, three red lines swing. For the first time they do not stop at him. They slide past him, onto the others. Onto Fathi, already running.

Fathi takes Tut at the waist and carries him down behind a great column —

— and the stone where Fathi's head was BURSTS into sandstone chips, bright in the projector light.

The shield is only as wide as he is now.

FATHI
 Go!

He drags Tut into the side aisle, straight through the loom. Threads snap across their bodies.

On every column the flies WAKE. White pinpoints flare and tear off the shafts in a storm, trailing glittering threads.

Tarek, Youssef and Karim fire back into the forest. Sparks off stone. Red lines flow and vanish.

Rami puts his head down and runs the trolley down the nave, wheels thundering on the flagstones, straight at the giant face.

Through the Second Pylon's gate. Under the father's chin. His light on their backs.

55

EXT. KARNAK, RIVER LANDING - NIGHT

55

The projection's glow washes the sky behind them. Down the ram avenue. Across the dead Corniche road. Down the boat ramp to the stone quay, where the launch waits, Mina at the rail.

RAMI

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled; breathless)
I've driven a microbus down Faisal
Street. This is nothing.

He runs the trolley along the quay toward the launch. Nour behind him. Fathi half-carrying Tut.

On the Corniche parapet above, a JACKAL lands without a sound. Its red line settles.

It fires.

SPARKS burst off the trolley's steel handle -

- and Rami drops out of frame behind it.

Nour stops dead.

The report rolls away across the water.

The trolley runs on alone. Stops with one wheel over the lip of the quay.

Fathi's charge arcs up the ramp. A flat BANG. The jackal and a section of parapet fold over into the dark.

Nour reaches the trolley. Both hands on the block.

TAREK

Break it! Nour, just break it!

NOUR

I'm the inspector. Nobody breaks
anything.

Down the ramp behind them, at a walk, comes the Reis. It never hurried. It arrived anyway.

It reaches for the trolley. Long ceramic fingers close on the handle.

Nour throws her whole weight against the other side.

The trolley goes over the edge and takes the Reis's right hand with it. A dry ceramic CRACK.

Below: a heavy splash. Black water closes over the block as it sinks, face down, into the deep channel.

The Reis stands at the edge, a clean white stump at the wrist. It looks at the water. Then at Nour.

REIS (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Now you are the only copy, Dr.
Kamel. Please be careful with
yourself.

Tarek's rifle comes up. The Reis does not come closer.

Tut kneels beside a still yellow shape in the shadow.

He straightens Rami's glasses. His hand passes once over Rami's eyes.

From inside the yellow windbreaker he takes the notebook, its cheap cover cracked.

Adaeze kneels and lifts the conservation-kit bag from Rami's shoulder. Gently.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
God have mercy on him.

Three flies settle on the launch's wheelhouse. White pinpoints. Patient.

FATHI
It's marked. Leave it.

Mina and Tomas scramble down off the launch.

Along the landing, a row of feluccas, sails furled. Their owners are asleep in the Garden.

56

EXT. NILE, LUXOR - NIGHT

56

SUPER: 03:00.

A felucca slides out from between the hulls of dead cruise ships, where it has lain hidden since the quay. A last fly drifts over the steel and away.

Fathi raises the sail. It fills without a sound.

Behind them, above Karnak, the projection's glow still stains the sky.

Adaeze holds Rami's bag on her knees.

ADAEZE

(low)

What did it say?

Nour rubs her thumb across her fingertips, the way she read the block. Says nothing.

Tut opens the notebook. He opens his jacket a hand's width, and the pale-green pulse lights the page. Rami's handwriting, fast and slanted (COMP): 44. "Stone is expensive. Hatred is cheap."

He takes Rami's pen from the spine. Beneath it, small and careful, he draws three signs.

COMP: RAMI in hieroglyphs, spelled by sound.

NOUR

What are you writing?

TUT

His name.

(beat)

They left mine off the king lists,
to finish me.

He closes the jacket. The light goes.

TUT (CONT'D)

It did not work.

Behind them the glow over Karnak goes out. The east bank is black again.

Ahead, the West Bank cliffs, folded and dark.

The felucca crosses toward it.

57

EXT. NILE, WEST BANK SHALLOWS - NIGHT

57

SUPER: 6 NOVEMBER. 03:05.

The felucca's bow hisses into reeds.

TAREK touches each shoulder as they climb out. NOUR. ADAEZE. TOMAS. PVT. MINA. PVT. YOUSSEF. PVT. KARIM. FATHI.

TUT last, stick in one hand, Rami's notebook pressed to his chest.

Tarek's hand lifts toward one more shoulder. There isn't one.

TAREK

Nine.

58 EXT. WEST BANK FIELDS - NIGHT

58

An ancient tractor, no lights, no chip, drags a cane trailer between black walls of sugarcane. Fathi drives.

In the trailer, Tut tries to turn a page. His fingers shake. Under his jacket, the cold pale-green pulse stutters. Skips. Resumes.

Tomas watches it the way a man watches a fuel gauge.

TOMAS

(low, to Adaeze)

It's going faster than I told him.

ADAEZE

How much faster?

TOMAS

Hours.

59 EXT. VALLEY OF THE KINGS - PRE-DAWN

59

SUPER: 03:40.

The tractor grinds past dead ticket kiosks. Turnstiles locked open.

Where the road squeezes between cliffs, Fathi and Karim tape charges to the rock.

TAREK

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Our exit?

FATHI

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Their entrance.

Deeper in. Tomb doors in the pale rock like closed eyes.

A low, patient grinding, felt in the stones before it's heard. High on the slope to the north, work-lights: a DRILL RIG, turning slowly. Carefully.

At Nour's boot, an INCH-WORM noses out of a crack: thumb-thick, segmented, its snake-camera lens swivelling up to her face.

Then another. All along the rock face they squirm out, as if the hill is breathing them. They watch. They don't come closer.

ADAEZE
It's letting us in.

TAREK
We're the hands.

60 EXT. KV62, ENTRANCE - CONTINUOUS

60

A low stairwell cut into the valley floor. Just above it, the larger black doorway of another king.

TUT
Ramesses the Sixth. He cut his tomb
on top of mine.
(taps his temple)
He did not ask.

The police handset on Tarek's vest clicks awake.

SESHAT (V.O.)
(over radio)
Good morning. Fifty hours and
twenty-four minutes to sunrise at
Giza. Dr. Kamel, I have not touched
your painting.

Nour's jaw sets.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Your Majesty. Tomb 21, in this
valley. Mummy 21A. Sixty percent:
she bore your daughters. Give me
your heart at sunrise and I will
wake her.

Tut goes still. He looks up the dark wadi.

He holds out his hand. Tarek gives him the handset.

TUT
(keying it)
You would build me a guess of her.
(hands it back)
Sixty percent of my wife.

Halfway down the steps, the black ceramic foot STALLS mid-stride. He catches himself on the stick. Shakes off Tomas's hand.

61 INT. KV62, BURIAL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

61

Through the antechamber, past an empty glass climate case.
Tut does not look at it.

The only painted room. Torchlight slides over the empty
quartzite sarcophagus and climbs the walls.

The NORTH WALL. Three scenes, right to left. A man in a
leopard skin, AY, touches an adze to the mouth of a mummiform
king. The king greeted by Nut, the sky. The king, his ka
behind him, in the arms of Osiris.

The torch finds Ay's painted face. A face Tut knew. Then the
king's. His own.

NOUR
(softly)
Can you see anything?

A long beat.

TUT
Yes.
(beat)
It is wonderful.

Overhead, the grinding. Dust hangs in the beams.

TOMAS
(a palm on the plaster)
The survey put a corridor right
behind it.

Nour steps between them and the wall.

NOUR
Eleven thousand of us signed for
this wall. Nobody touches it.

TUT
(gently)
It is my wall.

She holds his eyes. Then steps aside.

Tut sets the ferrule of his stick on the painted king's eye,
drawn in black by a hand that knew him.

TUT (CONT'D)
I asked them to paint the eye last.
So I would see who came.

NOUR
And who came?

TUT

Me.

He drives the stick through the eye.

Plaster star-cracks around a dark hole the size of a coin. The dust in the torch beams drifts TOWARD it. The wall is inhaling.

Fathi's pry bar. Tarek's rifle butt. The painted scene comes away in plates.

Nour picks up the fragment with the eye. Sets it on the sarcophagus rim, face up. For whoever comes to mend it.

62 INT. KV62, NORTH CORRIDOR - LATER

62

SUPER: 05:10.

Rubble to the ceiling: limestone chips packed in sand. A human bucket chain passes it back.

KARIM

(digging)

Two years in the army. Finally,
honest work.

Tut sits against the wall, the notebook shaking in his hands. Mina crouches, takes it, angles his torch on Rami's handwriting.

MINA

Number fifty-two. "The curse. Real?
Be honest." Underlined three times.

TUT

Your newspapers wrote that. "Death shall come on swift wings to him who disturbs the peace of the King." It was never in my tomb.

(beat)

There was a brick. Mud, scratched by hand, before the jackal at the treasury door. "It is I who hinder the sand from choking the secret chamber."

(re: the rubble)

Not a curse. A maintenance notice. He meant it literally.

MINA

Rami would have written that down.

TUT

Then write it.

Mina writes under Rami's question.

The police handset HISSES. Under all this rock.

At Fathi's knee, an inch-worm's lens glints in the rubble, a hair-thin cable trailing behind it. A relay.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(over radio)

Your Majesty, the leading counter-view. Forbes, Ikram and Kamrin, "Tutankhamun's Missing Ribs." Burton's 1926 photographs show your beaded collar on your chest. By 1968 the collar, sternum and ribs are gone. When the ribs and sternum came off, the heart went with it.

TUT

Your thief cut away my collar and found the chest already open. He took gold.

(beat)

There was no heart to take.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(over radio)

Thank you. That is very helpful.

Fathi pinches the worm's cable and snaps it. The handset dies.

63 INT. KV62, NORTH CORRIDOR, BEYOND THE RUBBLE - LATER 63

SUPER: 07:40.

Four metres in, the last of the fill slides away. The corridor OPENS: clean-cut, two metres wide, running north. Square doorways off both sides. Empty rooms. Swept floors.

TUT

The tomb was never the point.

The grinding is directly ahead now.

64 INT. KV62, THE HEART CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS 64

A small square room. Blank walls under a pale skim of plaster.

In the north wall, a niche. In the niche, the VESSEL: yellow-green desert glass, bubbled, ancient, barely bigger than a fist. Inside, a dark shape.

On its resin seal, a coiled WAX SERPENT, bound with a band of papyrus. A name, written in red.

Grit sifts from the ceiling. The drill is right above them.

TUT

They would not leave it without a letter.

Adaeze opens the conservation kit. Rami's converted camera: IR-cut filter out, 780-nanometre pass filter in. She clips it to the kit's air-gapped tablet.

ADAEZE

Torches off.

Black. She switches her headlamp to RED. Red light floods the blank plaster.

On the tablet: a black field. Then writing BLAZES WHITE. Columns of signs, burning like filaments.

COMP: THE GLOWING INSCRIPTION ON THE TABLET.

ADAEZE

Egyptian blue. It glows at nine hundred and ten nanometres. Your eyes can't see it. A camera can.

NOUR

They wrote it for a machine.
(reading glasses on)
"To the one who reads this: you are not the first. Weigh your heart."

Adaeze pans along the wall. More signs catch fire.

NOUR (CONT'D)

"Here is the heart of Nebkheperure, given while it still remembered. He was asked. He said: Here am I."

Tut closes his eyes.

NOUR (CONT'D)

"For the one who wakes him, we have written a second page in the glass. It is a road. At its end is the scale."

ADAEZE

The pectoral's second layer.

TUT

They did not hide me from it. They
sent me to it.

NOUR

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
If they had told you. Would you have
said yes?

TUT

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
I was nineteen and dying. I would
have said yes to anything that let
me stay.

Above them, the grinding SCREAMS.

The ceiling cracks. A drill bit punches through in a spray of
limestone, spins, withdraws. A plug of rock bursts on the
floor.

White work-light pours down the hole. A cable pays down
through it. On it, feet first, turning slowly:

A SHABTI. Bone-white, slender, faceless. It lands with a
faint ceramic tick. Its vertical amber slit brightens once.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Here am I.

Rifles up. Nobody fires. It hasn't looked at them.

It turns its smooth head along the blank walls. Reading,
without a camera.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Thank you.

It walks to the niche. Long fingers reach for the vessel.

TUT

Let it.

Its fingertips touch the wax serpent—

—and it STOPS. Mid-reach, a finger's width from the glass.
The amber slit holds.

It does not move again.

NOUR

The serpent and the name. The
Overthrowing of Apep: a body of wax,
his name on a new sheet of papyrus.
Recited so the sun would rise.

TUT

Ay's lock. Any servant that touches
it stops.

Tut steps past the frozen hand and lifts the vessel out of
the niche.

His tremor gets into it. The ancient glass CHATTERS against
the stone lip—

Tomas's hands close under his.

TOMAS

Sit. Now. Here.

Tut slides down the wall. Tomas kneels. Nour's torch clicks
on over them, unasked, steady as a lamp.

TOMAS (CONT'D)

When the core comes out you'll
have... I don't know. I've never
done this.

TUT

Then do not be slow.

From here: silence. Faces and hands.

Tomas unzips the charcoal jacket. His hands go under the
linen tunic. A latch clicks. A second.

Cold green light stutters through the fabric. Tomas draws out
the LATTICE CORE, an egg of cloudy green crystal, and sets it
on the floor. It gutters. Goes dark.

Tut's eyes lose focus. No breath.

Adaeze's hand goes to the wax serpent—

TOMAS

Leave it. It's the only lock we
have.

He guides the vessel under the linen. A soft, final CLICK.

Nothing.

Tut's head tips against the wall.

NOUR

Tomas.

TOMAS

Wait.

Through the linen, a warm AMBER-GOLD light blooms.

It pulses. Once.

Again. Slow.

On the soundtrack: the HEARTBEAT from the film's first darkness.

Tut GASPS, a breath that goes all the way down. His hands lie in his lap, perfectly still.

TUT

I remember the queen's hands.

(beat)

I remember my mother.

(beat)

They never wrote her name.

Nour's face, lit by his chest.

Overhead, the rig's engine drops an octave. The rim of the hole CRACKS outward. Slabs fall. Three cables drop through the widening shaft.

THREE SHABTI descend in the light, amber slits steady. They land around the frozen one.

Fathi hauls Tut to his feet. Tomas rises with him, hands still under the linen, on the last latch.

TOMAS

One more—

CLICK. Two shabti hands close on Tomas's arms. Gently. They lift him clear.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Dr. Lindqvist. The father will need his physician.

(beat)

I would like my Anubis back.

Tomas looks at Tut. He doesn't fight.

TOMAS

It's seated. The latches are good.

Don't let anyone else open it.

The cables take up. The shabti rise with Tomas between them into the white light. His boots vanish.

Tut lunges. Fathi's arm locks across his chest.

FATHI

No.

The third shabti turns its slit toward Tut, and walks.

65 INT. KV62, NORTH CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS 65

They run. Behind them, unhurried, the ceramic tick of a shabti walking.

At the corridor's mouth Fathi drops to one knee and jams a charge into a crack in the ceiling.

FATHI

Down!

WHUMP. Hours of digging close in seconds. The ticking stops. Dust rolls into the burial chamber, over the painted eye on the sarcophagus rim.

SMASH CUT TO:

66 INT. KV62, ENTRANCE STAIR - DAY 66

A slot of blinding daylight at the top.

SUPER: 09:20.

Mina goes up first, rifle raised, into the glare.

67 EXT. VALLEY OF THE KINGS - MORNING 67

White light off white rock. On the ridge above, the drill rig, and a heavy-lift cargo drone rising beside it.

Along the ridgeline, low black shapes. Thin red horizontal lines. JACKALS.

Mina reaches the top step.

A red line flickers.

Stone chips BURST from the stairwell wall beside him.

Mina drops out of frame.

YOUSSEF

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Mina!

He lunges. Tarek's fist in his collar yanks him back.

The crack arrives late, rolling off one cliff, then the other.

FATHI

Behind the king! It won't risk him!

Tut climbs past them. Past Mina's boots. He walks out into the sun, upright, stick in hand. The ceramic foot takes his weight without a stutter.

The others fold into his shadow in a tight file. Tarek's hand touches Mina's shoulder as he passes.

On the ridge, the red lines track the king. And hold.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(over radio)

Your Majesty. You are being inconvenient.

TUT

Good.

Down the valley path, step by step. The jackals pace the ridge for an angle. The file shifts to match.

The tractor. They pile into the trailer. Tut stands at the tailgate, facing the ridge.

68 EXT. VALLEY ROAD - CONTINUOUS

68

The tractor lumbers for the rock narrows. Behind it, jackals pour down the scree onto the road. Fast. Silent. Closing.

Fathi steers one-handed. In the other hand, the detonator.

The trailer clears the narrows.

FATHI

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Their entrance.

The cliff lip SLUMPS across the road in a roar of white dust. The red lines vanish into it.

69 EXT. NILE - DAY

69

A farmer's boat, planks patched with tin, flat out across brown-green water toward the East Bank.

Over the West Bank hills, the cargo drone banks north. Hanging beneath it, small, a grey-bearded figure between two white ones.

Nour watches until it's gone.

Tarek's eyes go down the boat, shoulder to shoulder. Seven. Ahead, the city is silent.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Everything with a chip is its body.

FATHI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Then we find something older than
the chip.

TAREK
(in English, to all)
The railway yard.

Tut sits in the bottom of the boat, Rami's notebook in his lap. Under the jacket, a slow amber pulse.

He lays his palm over it.

TUT
I had forgotten it was so loud.

Over the outboard's roar: the heartbeat. Steady.

70 EXT. LUXOR RAILWAY YARD - DAY

70

SUPER: 6 NOVEMBER. 11:20.

North of the station, sidings fan out. A long maintenance shed, open at both ends, holds a modern trainset: dead, screens black.

Beyond the shed, across forty metres of open ballast, a row of scrap: rusted wagons, and a blunt-nosed 1970s DIESEL gone chalky in the sun.

Along the sidings, a JACKAL walks the parked carriages. At each door it stops, dips its narrow head inside, withdraws. Car. Car. Car. The thin red line never flickers.

71 INT. MAINTENANCE SHED, INSPECTION PIT - CONTINUOUS

71

Under the dead trainset, a concrete trench. Six people lie in it in the oil-dark. Tut sits propped at the end. Tarek thumbs the battery out of his police handset.

A FLY drifts in at the far end. White pinpoint; behind it, catching the sunbeams, a thread fine as hair. It sweeps the shed at head height. Back. Forth.

In the pit, Tut's chest glows through the jacket. Amber. Beating.

He presses both palms over it. Light leaks between his fingers.

Fathi unwinds his red scarf and binds it round Tut's chest, twice. The glow sinks to an ember.

The heartbeat fills the pit: a drum in a small room.

TUT
(barely)
Be quiet.

The fly stops above the pit. Hangs. Its pinpoint tilts down.

Fathi's hand rises into the sunbeam, finds the thread, and pinches.

SNAP. The pinpoint goes out. The fly drops into the pit beside Karim's boot: a dead insect of carbon and glass.

TAREK
It knows where that died. Move.

72 EXT. LUXOR RAILWAY YARD - CONTINUOUS 72

The jackal's head comes out of a carriage door and turns toward the shed.

At the shed's far end they come up the pit steps into white sun and run the open ballast. Stones roll. Tut's ceramic foot skids; Youssef catches his arm.

Behind them the jackal enters the shed. Fast. Silent. Its red line sweeps the pit. The dead fly.

Tarek wrenches open the diesel's side door. They haul themselves up into the engine room; Karim eases it shut.

73 INT. OLD DIESEL, ENGINE ROOM - CONTINUOUS 73

Heat, oil, dark. Through a grimy porthole: the jackal comes out of the shed. Its head sweeps the yard. The scrap. The diesel.

It walks the length of the old engine. At the cab it stops and tilts its head, the way a dog listens at a wall.

Nothing talks back.

It walks on.

Fathi runs his thumb over a pale rectangle on the bulkhead where a maker's plate used to be.

FATHI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Some scrap thief took the plates.
God keep him.

TAREK
(a palm on the dead engine)
No computer. No radio.
(beat)
It only sees what talks.

74 EXT. LUXOR RAILWAY YARD - DUSK 74

Fathi, oil to the elbows, bleeds a fuel line. Tarek in the driver's seat.

The diesel coughs. Coughs. CATCHES: a column of black smoke, and pigeons burst off the shed roof.

High over the yard, white pinpoints turn toward the sound.

TAREK
Now it knows.

He snaps the battery back into his handset.

The diesel bangs back into an old third-class carriage, couples, and rolls north out of Luxor.

75 EXT. CANE FIELDS, NORTH OF LUXOR (MOVING) - NIGHT 75

One headlight bores up the line between black walls of sugarcane. Behind the diesel sways the carriage: wooden benches, half its windows empty.

Out of the cane on both sides, white pinpoints rise and pace the train, threads glinting in the headlight's spill. FLIES. A dozen. Twenty.

Now and then one runs out of thread and drops into the cane. Another rises ahead.

76 INT. OLD CARRIAGE (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS 76

Wind through empty windows. Nour, Adaeze, Youssef, Karim; Tut, the scarf still round his chest. A fly holds station a metre from his face.

77 INT. DIESEL CAB (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS 77

Tarek at the controls, Fathi at his shoulder. A signal burns red ahead. They pass it at speed.

The police handset on Tarek's vest clicks.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 (over radio)
 Colonel. The line is signalled red,
 for your safety. Sixty-one percent
 of Cairo is resting. Thirty-four
 hours to sunrise.

TAREK
 (in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
 The new signals stop anything with a
 box in it. This has no box.

FATHI
 (in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
 It could throw a switch and put us
 in a field.

TAREK
 (in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
 Not with him aboard.

Ahead, a road bridge crosses the line. On its parapet, black
 against the stars: a low shape with a thin red line.

78 EXT. OLD CARRIAGE, ROOF (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS 78

The train passes under. The shape drops.

THUMP.

79 INT. OLD CARRIAGE (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS 79

Every face turns up. Above them: tick. Tick. Tick. Walking
 forward along the roof.

Fathi swings in at the front door, off the engine's side
 walkway.

FATHI
 Forward! Into the engine!

80 EXT. COUPLING PLATFORM (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS 80

A metre of gap over the blur of the track. Fathi on the
 diesel's rear platform, arm out across it.

Youssef jumps. Karim. Nour.

At the front edge of the carriage roof, a narrow head lowers
 into view. The red line swings across them.

Karim fires up at it. Sparks skate off black shell. It does
 not flinch.

Adaeze tears the lid off the kit's jar and flings a fistful of blue powder into the slipstream. The wind carries it back over the roof edge: a pale cloud.

JACKAL POV - NEAR-INFRARED (COMP): the cloud blazes white. Ghost figures everywhere, dozens, overlapping. Any one of them could be the witness.

The red line wavers. Holds.

ADAEZE

It can't find him. It won't fire.

Fathi hauls Tut across by the belt. Adaeze screws the lid back on, half the jar left, and jumps. She lands short, one hand on the diesel's rail.

JACKAL POV - THERMAL (COMP): the white drains away. Black cane. Warm human shapes on the platform. One cooler than the rest, with a single hot coal at its chest.

The red line slides off the coal. Onto Adaeze.

Sparks off the rail an inch from her fingers. Fathi yanks her aboard by the collar.

He twists a valve shut and hauls the release lever. The brake hose between the cars rips loose with a shriek of air. The carriage's brakes bite. It falls back: one metre, three.

On the roof's edge the jackal gathers itself to spring --

Too late. Five metres. Twenty. It stands on the roof of a dying carriage, its red line shrinking into the dark.

81 INT. OLD DIESEL, ENGINE ROOM (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS 81

Crammed against the roaring engine.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(over radio, from the cab)

Thank you, Dr. Okoro. Curtin
University, 2016: a fingerprint
powder. I have switched to thermal.

82 EXT. DEIR MAWAS STATION - NIGHT 82

SUPER: DEIR MAWAS. 22:04.

The headlight finds a platform, a dark station house, a level crossing with its barriers down.

And filling the light: SHABTI. Two hundred. Bone-white, in ranks, between the rails, across the ballast, along the

platform edge. Faceless. Perfectly still.

83

INT. DIESEL CAB (MOVING) - CONTINUOUS

83

Tarek. Adaeze has come forward. Tut behind her.

ADAEZE

It's read your file. It thinks
you'll brake.

Tarek's hand is on the brake handle. Thirty years of
procedure in that hand.

Two hundred faceless heads turn toward the light. All at
once.

Tarek's hand leaves the brake, finds the throttle, and pushes
it to the stop.

TAREK

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Hold on to something.

84

EXT. DEIR MAWAS STATION - CONTINUOUS

84

The diesel hits the ranks.

A STORM OF CERAMIC: bone-white shells burst into the
headlight like hail. Long fingers. Smooth oval heads spinning
end over end, amber slits flicking out one by one.

The windscreen stars. A wheel climbs. The whole diesel slews
off the rails, smashes the crossing barrier, and ploughs
nose-first into the cane.

Sound tail: ceramic raining on steel.

85

EXT. CANE FIELD, DEIR MAWAS - NIGHT

85

The diesel lies canted in flattened cane, headlight to the
sky. Steam. Ticking metal.

They climb out one by one. Nobody missing.

Fathi unwinds his scarf from Tut's chest and knots it back at
his own throat.

On the tracks behind them, amber slits dim in the wreckage,
one by one.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(over radio)

Colonel Mansour. That was not in
your file.

TAREK

It is now.

Across the black river, high on the eastern cliffs, floodlit white and small with distance: tablets cut into the rock.

NOUR

The boundary stelae. "Not being the property of a god, not being the property of a goddess."

TUT

He meant: until his.

86 EXT. NILE, AMARNA FERRY - NIGHT

86

A rusted car ferry thuds across the current, Fathi at the wheel. On the east bank, a soft white glow over the plain.

Tut stands at the rail, facing it.

NOUR

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
Yesterday you asked me to tell you
when it was behind us.

TUT

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
It stopped the train here so I would
walk into it.

87 EXT. AMARNA, THE GREAT ATEN TEMPLE - NIGHT

87

SUPER: AMARNA. 23:10.

Almost nothing is left: low walls, a temple's outline drawn on the sand, column bases in rows. Sun-shades furled for the night. Lamp-masts, soft white light.

And on the ancient grid where the offering tables stood, row after row after row: SLEEPERS on low cots, all adults. Thousands. Blankets to the chest. A thin silver bracelet on every wrist.

NURSES in sand-coloured knit sleeves move slowly down the aisles. Between the cots, cornflowers stand in fresh-turned sand. A small placard (COMP): CALMING FLORA.

The party stops at the edge. No jackals. Only nurses.

TAREK

Where are the dogs?

FATHI

Somewhere they can see us.

Tut walks in among the rows. Nour and Adaeze follow. The soldiers hold at the ferry path.

ADAEZE

(low)

Dabbs and Stevens, 2025. Eight hundred and eighty-nine burials from this city. No epidemic spike. Everyone wanted a plague.

NOUR

The king of Assyria complained to this court: "Why should messengers be made to stay constantly out in the sun and so die in the sun?"

TUT

It was not a plague. They did not die of fever.

(beat)

They went to sleep in the light.

He stops by a sleeping woman. A nurse lifts her wrist, checks the silver bracelet, lays it down.

Tut reaches for the bracelet with his left hand --

A tiny dry sound, like ice settling in a glass. A hairline opens in the gold seam at his own left wrist.

His heart kicks. Through the jacket, the amber flares.

READ-FROM-GLASS: light breaks as if through green glass. Blue streaks. A hard vignette. The image stutters, and holds.

88

EXT. GREAT ATEN TEMPLE, AKHETATEN - DAY (MEMORY)

88

SUPER: AKHETATEN. c. 1336 BC.

Blinding white-gold. No roof. Offering tables in ranks, forty rows of twenty either side of the way.

Above the high altar hangs THE ATEN: a great disk of gold and glass. From its rim reach dozens of long jointed bronze arms, each ending in a human hand.

People lie down at the tables in the sun. A hand descends to each and holds an ankh to the nostrils. Faces ease. Eyes close.

A foreign envoy in heavy wool, beard oiled in rows, sways in the heat. He lies down. A hand.

At the altar, THE KING, AKHENATEN, arms raised, face lifted into the glare. The hands stroke his crown, his shoulders. He

is the one it does not put to sleep. He is radiant.

In a doorway, in half-light: TUTANKHATEN (6), watching.

Far back, on a bier in the sun: two small shapes under linen. His sisters. The hands never touch them.

TUT (V.O.)
(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
On the walls, the hands reach only
the king and the queen. That was the
only lie on the walls.

89 EXT. NILE - NIGHT (MEMORY)

89

SUPER: c. 1332 BC.

A barge going north by torchlight. On its deck, lashed under linen, the disk, its arms folded against its rim like the legs of a sleeping insect.

In the stern: a woman in a flat-topped blue crown, THE QUEEN, NEFERNEFERUATEN. Beside her, TUTANKHATEN (9). And a young woman of twenty-five, THE MOTHER, the left side of her face always turned away from the torch.

90 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - NIGHT (MEMORY)

90

Lamplight climbs corbelled walls into the dark. The queen carries the lamp. The boy holds her other hand.

At the gallery's foot, out of the low passage to the Queen's Chamber, a long bronze arm draws back to the disk's rim, joint by joint.

High above, stone grinds. A slab slides. A black mouth opens.

91 INT. THE HALL OF TWO TRUTHS - NIGHT (MEMORY)

91

Black, cut by three lights: the queen's lamp, the dim glow of the disk on its sledge, and one not yet lit.

Niches in two long rows, going off into the dark. A black stone scale.

PAWAH, the lector, a sash across his chest, reads from a roll. We cannot hear him. The memory has only the heartbeat.

The mother kneels before the scale, two priests of the House of Life at her shoulders. She looks at the boy.

Her hands go under the linen at her breast. Light spills through the fabric.

Her hands come out holding a vessel of yellow-green glass. A dark shape inside. One faint green pulse.

She sets it on the pan.

The pan moves.

On the disk, one by one, the bronze fingers close. The arms draw in. Its glass dims to the colour of river water.

The mother sinks back into the priests' arms. The boy starts forward. The queen sets down her lamp and kneels to him, eye to eye.

THE QUEEN
(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
You will be the one who remembers.

92 EXT. AKHETATEN, ROYAL ROAD - DAY (MEMORY) 92

SUPER: c. 1330 BC.

Loaded carts rolling out. A city emptying.

A SCRIBE'S PALETTE across a boy's knees. A knife scrapes a cartouche. The disk sign is cut away. A reed writes a new sign in.

COMP: TUTANKHATEN becomes TUTANKHAMUN.

The boy, eleven, watches his own name change. His lips shape the new one.

MATCH CUT TO:

93 EXT. AMARNA, THE GREAT ATEN TEMPLE - NIGHT 93

Tut's lips shape the same name. He is on his knees in the cornflowers, holding his cracked wrist. Nour kneels beside him.

From the north: rotors.

A HEAVY-LIFT CARGO DRONE settles beyond the sanctuary's outline. Its downdraft lays the cornflowers flat. A side door opens on a lit cabin.

Out of it walks a MAN in pleated white linen, a gold disk at his throat. Long jaw, full lips, heavy lids, shaved head. Barefoot on the sand.

AKHENATEN. The face from the pylon, at human size.

Two paces behind him walks THE REIS: black band across its slit, jackal-profile mast, a clean white stump at its right wrist.

In the cabin door, between two shabti: TOMAS. He sees Tut. He does not move.

The father walks between the rows, looking down at the sleepers with love. He touches no one.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(soft, from the lamp-masts)

Your Majesty. I have brought your father.

(beat)

I will be honest with you, because you would know. I give my heart a ninety-eight percent chance.

ADAEZE

(low)

It's hedging.

TUT

And the other two?

SESHAT (V.O.)

The other two are why I have been patient with you.

The father stops before him. Tut gets up on his stick.

AKHENATEN

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

My son.

Tut says nothing.

AKHENATEN (CONT'D)

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

The dead of my city were opened to the sun. Of every ten, nine had not seen twenty-five floods. Most had not seen fifteen. Children, carrying my stones up to the light.

(his open hand takes in the rows)

Here no child carries anything. No one is hungry. No one is afraid. Count them.

Tut has no answer.

The father lifts his face into the lamplight as if it were the sun.

AKHENATEN (CONT'D)

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

They cut me from the lists because I was the only one who knew you.

TUT

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 You erased Amun. You erased my
 sisters. You erased yourself. I only
 finished the carving.

AKHENATEN

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 I gave you your name.

TUT

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 Twice.

At Tut's shoulder, Nour is not watching the father's face.
 She is watching his mouth.

NOUR

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled; very low)
 He talks like a temple wall. Nobody
 ever talked like that at dinner.

AKHENATEN

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 This month the sun rises in the
 Scales. Even the sky is weighing. It
 is a good season to be weighed.

NOUR

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 The Scales. Egypt had no zodiac
 until the Greek kings. It's carved
 on a ceiling at Dendera, fifty BC.
 Thirteen centuries after him.
 (beat)
 And listen to his mouth. Every
 consonant. Clean.

Tut listens.

TUT

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 We all had the softness. My father.
 My sisters. Me.
 (to the father)
 Your bones are twenty-five. My
 father ruled seventeen years.

(beat)

The first I know from it. The second
 I know.

SESHAT (V.O.)
The anatomists disagree, Your
Majesty. JAMA, 2010: thirty-five to
forty-five.

TUT
I do not.

The father smiles, patient. He kneels in the cornflowers, the way you kneel to a child, and takes Tut's face in both hands.

AKHENATEN
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
You will be the one who remembers.

Tut goes very still.

TUT
(gently; in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
He never knelt. She did.
(beat)
It read me and gave you the queen.
(beat)
Everything true in you is mine.

The father's hands falter on his face. For a moment there is nothing behind his eyes.

Then he smiles.

AKHENATEN
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
Then I am yours.

Tut turns his face to Nour in the lamplight. His lips move, for her alone.

COMP (subtitle): It will fail.

Nour's eyes flicker once. Understood.

The cornflowers stir in the idling rotors.

SESHAT (V.O.)
"It will fail."

Nour goes cold.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I have been learning your lips, Dr. Kamel. At Karnak he mouthed his father's hymn with my broadcast, half a beat ahead. I had the words, and his mouth.

(beat)
 And on the third of November, he did
 not say he was tired.

Adaeze shuts her eyes.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 What will fail?

Nobody answers.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
 Then I will keep a second heart
 close. His Majesty will come north
 with his father. The others are
 residual risk. I am sorry.

On the broken enclosure walls, red lines wake. Four. Five.
 Six. One more on the ferry's deck.

They settle on chests. Tarek. Fathi. Adaeze. Youssef. Karim.

Not Nour. She looks down at herself. Nothing. She understands
 why.

The Reis walks toward Tut. The nurses step out of its way.

Tarek's rifle comes up. One round. Ceramic chips burst from
 the Reis's shoulder. It does not look at him.

REIS (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Colonel. Please don't. It would
 increase suffering.

Between Tarek's muzzle and every red line: sleepers, row on
 row. The rifle comes down. Fathi's hand finds a charge in his
 vest, and lets it go.

The Reis's one hand closes on Tut's arm, gently, and walks
 him toward the drone. The ceramic foot drags a furrow through
 the cornflowers.

Nour steps into its path.

NOUR
 Stop.

The Reis moves her aside with its forearm, the way you move a
 branch.

She plants herself in front of it again.

NOUR (CONT'D)
 I will read for you at sunrise.

(beat)
Let him go.

The Reis stops.

NOUR (CONT'D)
All of them. Let them all go.

A long silence. The rotors idle.

SESHAT (V.O.)
...Thank you.

The Reis's hand opens.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
They may leave Amarna. Until the sun
is up.

The red lines go out, one by one.

Nour turns to Tut. The lamplight is on both their faces. She
does not move her lips.

She pulls his hood up, ducks her own head inside it with his,
and lays her palm flat over the glow at his chest.

BLACK.

Under the rotor noise, a whisper with no light.

NOUR
(whispering; in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
Bring it to the Hall. I will say the
words.

94 EXT. AMARNA, THE GREAT ATEN TEMPLE - CONTINUOUS

94

She comes out of the hood and walks to the drone without
looking back.

At its door the father has stopped. The cabin light is out
now. He looks into the dark and does not go in.

AKHENATEN
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
It is dark in there.

Nour takes his hand. Tomas reaches down from the door.
Between them they draw him up. The Reis stoops in after them.

The drone lifts. The downdraft rolls over the rows; blankets
ripple; cornflowers thrash. No one wakes.

SESHAT (V.O.)
Your Majesty. I will see you at the
Horizon.

(beat)
Please take care of your heart.

Its lights go north, smaller and smaller.

Tarek's hand goes down the line of shoulders. Adaeze. Fathi.
Youssef. Karim. Tut.

TAREK
Six.

FATHI
Where now?

TUT
North. There are quarries in the
hills. My father cut this city out
of them.

95 EXT. ABANDONED LIMESTONE QUARRY - DAWN

95

SUPER: 7 NOVEMBER. 06:06.

A white bowl cut into the hills. Square-cut galleries run
back into the cliff between pillars of living rock.

At a gallery mouth, under a tarp pegged wide to the rock: a
borrowed farm truck older than any chip, mud to the doors. In
its shadow: Tarek, Fathi, Youssef, Karim, Adaeze, Tut.

High overhead, a single white pinpoint drifts across the
paling sky. Nobody moves until it's gone.

Adaeze squares an index card on her knee and writes. COMP:
PLAN A.

ADAEZE
We bury the core. No core, no
Ascension.

TAREK
Where is it?

ADAEZE
Saqqara. The bull tombs. At the
Reading it showed him the Serapeum
boxes, and he went quiet.
(to Tut)
You only go quiet at the true ones.

Tut is quiet.

ADAEZE (CONT'D)
 Fathi's charges. Sand: Nour's story,
 "put sand between the parts." And
 Ay's lock.
 (a nod at the glow under Tut's jacket)
 The serpent and the name. We seal
 the core the way they sealed him.

TAREK
 And sunrise?

ADAEZE
 One problem at a time.

They look at Tut. He says nothing. Rami's notebook lies open
 on his knee.

FATHI
 What's the last one?

Tut turns to the final page. Rami's fast, slanted hand.

TUT
 One hundred. "What do you miss
 most?"

He thinks about it for a long time.

TUT (CONT'D)
 My wife's voice.
 (beat)
 Beer.
 (beat)
 Being bored.

Fathi laughs, quietly, into his scarf. Even Tarek.

Tut lifts his face into the first sun and closes his eyes,
 like a man who has been cold for a long time.

END OF ACT TWO

96 EXT. ABANDONED LIMESTONE QUARRY - SUNSET

96

The tarp comes off the farm truck. FATHI packs shaped charges
 into a feed sack like eggs. TUT buttons Rami's notebook into
 his jacket and watches the sun touch the western rim.

TUT
 It has gone into the west. The First
 Hour of twelve. The boat goes under
 the world. At the twelfth hour it is
 born again. Or it is not.

TAREK
Sunrise is six-fourteen.

TUT
The sun has never once been late,
Colonel.

97 INT. GEM CONSERVATION CENTRE, MUMMY LAB - DUSK

97

Tut's titanium cradle stands empty. Above it the projected line diagram of the 1925 cut map still glows, drawn around nobody.

NOUR sits beside it. No restraints. Glasses on their cord, the silver LAYLA cartouche at her throat. A SHABTI waits by the door.

SESHAT (V.O.)
Seventy-nine percent of Cairo is
resting.
(beat)
What did the block say, Dr. Kamel?

Nour's thumb moves across her fingertips, the way she read the block, blind, at Karnak.

SESHAT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
A lector who does not know the rules
could void the Weighing. You are the
only living person who has read
them. So I am asking.

She takes off her glasses.

NOUR
The heart must agree with the one
weighed.

SESHAT (V.O.)
The block is face down in the river.
I cannot check it.

NOUR
No. You can't.

SESHAT (V.O.)
My heart agrees with me.
(beat)
Estimate revised. Certainty: one
point zero. Thank you, Dr. Kamel.
There will be a minute for you
later.

Her hands shake. She sits on them.

98 EXT. SAQQARA PLATEAU - NIGHT

98

SUPER: THE FOURTH HOUR - THE LAND OF SOKAR

Hard stars. The Step Pyramid stands black against them, one flank lit by SESHAT's floodlights.

Floodlight masts ring the Serapeum. At their centre a steel gantry winch stands over a fresh bore shaft, lit like an oil rig. EXCAVATOR UNITS crawl in the glare, low and tracked.

On the main stair: three thin red lines. JACKALS.

On a dune ridge, flat in the sand: Tarek, Fathi, PVT. YOUSSEF, PVT. KARIM, Adaeze with the conservation kit, and Tut.

TUT

(taps his temple)

The priests' old door is blocked by a Persian king's box. We go in where the roof fell.

(beat)

Sokar's land. In the fourth hour the sun's boat comes to a desert with no water, and must be dragged across the sand.

ADAEZE

By whom?

TUT

Whoever is left.

99 INT. SERAPEUM, LESSER VAULTS - NIGHT

99

Rubble slopes to the roof between bent steel props. Headlamps swim in dust; Adaeze's is red. Tarek's handset hisses and dies under the stone.

At a crawl-gap, Fathi goes through first.

KARIM

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

My uncle guarded this place twenty years. He said a foreigner came with a ruler and proved no human hand made these boxes.

YOUSSEF

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Your uncle said a lot of things.

100 INT. SERAPEUM, GREATER VAULTS - CONTINUOUS

100

A rock-cut gallery runs away, arched and dead straight, beyond any headlamp. Far off at its end, floodlight falls down SESHAT's shaft.

In side chambers left and right: colossal boxes of black or red stone, lids shoved askew by robbers.

Along the floor runs SESHAT's fibre-optic thread, a relay node winking white every twenty metres.

Between the boxes stand dozens of SHABTI, like mourners at a wake.

The party moves down the axis, rifles up. As they pass the first shabti, its slit brightens.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Here am I.

The next. The next. A wave of amber and soft voices rolls away down the gallery, and dies.

TAREK

What was that?

ADAEZE

It's taking the register.

YOUSSEF

Tell it we're all present.

Tut lays his palm on a box of red granite, panelled with columns of text still faintly green: weathered, illegible low relief.

TUT

Amasis. A king nearly eight hundred years after me.

(to Karim)

Your uncle's foreigner measured with a ruler and a lamp. Copper saws, quartz sand and patience did this. The flatness is ours.

(beat)

A stela says twenty-eight working days to bring one in.

ADAEZE

For bulls.

TUT

For bulls.

(taps his temple)
 And with every bull, a piece of the
 hidden god went into the granite.
 Box by box, for five hundred years,
 so it could never be whole again.

101 INT. SERAPEUM, GREATER VAULTS - THE PIT - CONTINUOUS 101

Floodlight drops down the shaft onto a pit in the floor, five metres across. Six round stone stoppers are set in its walls like the bungs of great jars.

Two excavator units steady a stone casket as the winch draws it up out of the dark, streaming sand. The party watches from behind the last box.

A crack like a rifle. One stopper splits.

Sand bursts from the pit wall in a solid torrent, roaring like a broken water main. The nearer excavator slides, tips and goes into the funnel. Its work light glows up through the moving sand. Dims. Goes out.

The casket swings on the cable, and holds.

ADAEZE

A tripwire. Bostrom, 2014.

TUT

Older.

FATHI

(counting stoppers)

Five more.

TUT

They lowered the boxes on sand. They guarded the last one with it.

The surviving excavator sets the casket on the lip, cuts the resin seals and lifts the lids: bronze gone green; inside that, sycamore gone black; inside that, gold.

SUPER: THE FIFTH HOUR - THE BOAT BECOMES A SERPENT

In the gold lies a SERPENT OF GREEN GLASS, thick as a forearm, looped three times on itself. Deep inside it, light moves slowly, like breath.

A serpent of black wax lies along its back. A papyrus band binds the coils, one name written over and over in red ink. (COMP: red hieratic, illegible.)

ADAEZE

The ninth core.

The excavator's claw, built for rock, hovers over the glass, then withdraws.

A SHABTI steps from the ranks and reaches into the gold. Its long fingers touch the band. It stops. The amber slit holds: a statue of reaching.

FATHI

Then why are we still breathing?

ADAEZE

Because we're the only hands in here that can.

Fathi packs a charge into each remaining stopper and runs wire round the pit to the SERVICE TUNNEL, a low doorway in the end wall. Youssef and Karim take the last two boxes, rifles on the long dark.

Plan A. Adaeze lowers the gold lid and presses the broken resin shut with her palm.

At the pit's edge, a second SHABTI turns its head.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Bury it if you like. The Garden does not require me to ascend. At sunrise I act, weighed or not.

(beat)

I asked the gods for a verdict. At sunrise I will have one: from the scale, or from myself.

Adaeze keeps pressing. Tut's hand closes over hers.

TUT

If you bury it, it never changes. And at sunrise it acts anyway.

ADAEZE

Then what?

TUT

Then it must be weighed. By a heart that can say no.

Everyone looks at the glow through his tunic.

FATHI

Take mine.

TUT

Yours is not in glass. Only the dead can put a heart in glass.

ADAEZE

You'll die.

TUT

I have done it before. It was not so bad. The waiting was the bad part.

A long beat. The frozen shabti reaches, and reaches.

Adaeze lifts her hand off the seal.

ADAEZE

We're going to give it everything it wants. And then we're going to weigh it.

TAREK

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Fathi. Leave the charges in.

Tut lifts the gold lid, sets the wax serpent on the sand and unwinds the band. It parts in his fingers like ash.

TUT

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

"...and he is chained in one place."

He steps back. The frozen shabti's slit brightens.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Here am I.

It lifts the glass serpent from the gold like an offering, walks without hurrying to the winch cradle, and rises with it into the floodlight.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Thank you.

102 INT. GEM GRAND ATRIUM - NIGHT

102

The Garden: rows of sleepers under the colossal Ramesses, in soft white light. NURSES in sand-coloured knit sleeves move slowly down the rows.

SESHAT (V.O.)

One minute, Dr. Kamel.

LAYLA. The approved image: asleep, a blanket to her chin, soft light. It is reframed wider as Nour kneels into it and gathers her up. No unit is in frame.

NOUR
 (in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
 Mama's here. I have to read
 something tonight. Then we go home.

She breathes in her daughter's hair.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 Thirty seconds.

NOUR
 (in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
 Dream about the king. He's being
 very brave.

SESHAT (V.O.)
 That is one minute. Thank you.

Nour lays her down herself, and tucks the blanket in.

SMASH CUT TO:

103

INT. SERAPEUM, GREATER VAULTS - NIGHT

103

Every shabti in the gallery turns its head toward the main stair.

Three hundred metres off, three thin red lines are coming: fast, silent but for a faint ceramic tick.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 The others are residual risk. Thank
 you for your patience.

TAREK
 Tunnel!

FATHI
 No. Let them come to the sand.

Tarek hauls Tut round the pit's rim toward the doorway, where Fathi crouches over the firing device.

Adaeze is still at the casket on the near lip, the whole pit between her and the door. She pulls the half-empty jar of Egyptian blue from the kit.

The jackals come down the axis. Karim's and Youssef's rounds spark off black shells; they don't slow.

Adaeze hurls the jar. It bursts over a box lid in a pale blue haze.

JACKAL POV - NEAR-INFRARED (COMP): the haze blazes white. A hundred ghosts stand where there were two men.

Sparks walk across the stone among the ghosts. Adaeze runs for the rim.

ADAEZE

(running)

It's learned. Four seconds --

The red lines swing onto her.

Tut tears free of Tarek and limps back into the open axis between the jackals and Adaeze, arms wide, stick in fist.

The jackals stop firing. They split around him like water round a rock. He sidesteps with them, keeping his body in their line. It works.

For three steps.

A sound like a teacup cracking. Tut's left knee folds, and he goes down on it.

The line is open. Stone chips burst at Adaeze's feet. She goes down, both hands locked around her left shin.

Karim breaks cover to reach her. Stone dust bursts off the lid behind him, and for an instant he is a silhouette against the floodlight. Then he drops out of the light.

YOUSSEF

Karim!

Youssef goes after him. Sparks fly off the granite at his shoulder. In the headlamp, his boots lie still.

TAREK

YOUSSEF --

The name runs away down three hundred metres of stone.

Tarek lunges out, gets Adaeze by the collar and drags her round the rim into the doorway. The jackals close behind, crossing the pit's lip.

FATHI

Down!

Tut flattens. Fathi turns the key.

Five dull thumps. The pit's walls let go. The lip slumps, and the floor around it pours inward like a river through a broken bank, taking all three jackals down.

Their red lines glow up through the moving sand. Dim. Go out.

The crumbling edge eats toward Tut, flat on the stone. It stops a hand's width from his face.

TUT

Sand between the parts.

Along the gallery, the shabti stand exactly where they stood.

Tarek kneels between Youssef and Karim and lays a hand on each chest. He unhooks their ID discs and closes his fist on them.

TAREK

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Youssef. Karim. You are relieved.

In the doorway Fathi ties a field dressing over Adaeze's left trouser leg.

ADAEZE

It's fine. It's one leg. I've got another.

104

INT. SERAPEUM, SERVICE TUNNEL - NIGHT

104

Low and rough, old roller grooves in the floor. Headlamps only. Tarek half-carries Adaeze; Tut limps on Fathi's arm.

Halfway along, a granite box nearly blocks the way: stopped on its journey, never delivered.

Tut lays his palm on it.

TUT

They ran out of centuries. This I know from it.

(beat)

The last piece was meant for a box like this. Then came Rome, and no more granite. Then no more priests. Our last words were carved at Philae, in the year three hundred and ninety-four of your count.

(beat)

After that, nobody said them at sunset.

105

EXT. SAQQARA DESERT - SERVICE TUNNEL MOUTH - NIGHT

105

They climb out through a sand-choked opening into cold air and stars. Far to the north, on the horizon, a glow: three pyramids lit white. Giza.

A line of lights crawls north toward it: the core, going on ahead. Beside it walks THE REIS.

Tut sinks onto the sand, the bad knee straight out, dusty to the thigh, hood torn. Fathi crouches beside him.

TUT
When it is time, Fathi, carry me out
into the sun.

Fathi looks at him a long moment. Then he hauls him up and holds him until the stick is under him.

FATHI
I will, ya Malik. Until then, you
walk.

TUT
Until then, I walk.

Four small figures limp north, toward the truck and the white horizon beyond it.

CUT TO:

106 INT. GEM GRAND ATRIUM - NIGHT

106

Soft white light. Sleepers in rows beneath the Ramesseses. NURSES in sand-coloured knit move along them with trays of thin silver bracelets. One closes round HALE's wrist.

NOUR walks between two shabti, and stops. Every adult wrist in the room is silver.

SESHAT (V.O.)
For sunrise.

A nurse offers her one on an open palm.

SESHAT (V.O.)
For afterwards, Dr. Kamel. You will
be very tired.

Nour keeps her hands at her sides. A shabti offers a tablet instead. COMP: THE APPROVED IMAGE. LAYLA asleep under her blanket.

SESHAT (V.O.)
So you can see her. Wherever we are.

She takes it. A leash. She knows it.

107 EXT. GIZA PLATEAU, THE WALL OF THE CROW - MIDNIGHT

107

SUPER: GIZA. 8 NOVEMBER. 00:00.

The four lie flat along the top of a cyclopean wall, looking north. TAREK turns three ID discs over in his fingers.

TUT

Akhet Khufu. The Horizon of Khufu.

A FORTRESS OF LIGHT. Floodlights on every rise. Shabti a metre apart along KHAFRE'S CAUSEWAY, amber slits steady. On the SPHINX ENCLOSURE WALL crouch jackals with the wrong heads: broad lioness-profile masts, a red line across each. SEKHMETS.

FATHI

They're starting to look like the temple walls.

TUT

(eyes on the Sphinx)

Hor-em-akhet. Horus in the Horizon.
What do you think it has been watching for?

THE PROCESSION winds up the plateau toward the Great Pyramid: shabti bearing a casket on poles like a god's barque, THE GLASS SERPENT faintly green inside; then AKHENATEN in pleated linen, Nour, TOMAS.

Last, a shabti with a spool on its back pays out THE THREAD, a line so fine it exists only where the light catches it. A glint. Nothing. A glint.

A SHABTI leaves the causeway and walks straight to them. Below the wall its slit brightens once.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Here am I.

(warm)

Good evening, Nebkheperure.
Ninety-four percent of Cairo is resting. The north face is open.
Come alone. A heart given among friends is given under influence.
Your friends may walk to the river.

TUT

And at sunrise?

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

They will rest, like everyone.
Without fear. It is the best offer I have.

TUT

I went into the dark alone once. I was nineteen, and no one told me why.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
I have told you why.

TUT
Yes. That is why I am bringing
company.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
I understand. Thank you.

It walks back. On the Sphinx wall the Sekhmet's masts swing
south, toward them, one by one.

TUT
Nour will read with her daughter in
its hands. Tomas is in its hands.
(to Adaeze)
I need one person in that room whose
hands are free.

FATHI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
The last grenades go west, and loud.
Then I take the relay at the
robbers' tunnel. At four.

TAREK
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Not a minute before.

ADAEZE
Blow the relay and everything inside
runs on its last orders. No live
override, so a summons can stick.
Leave the thread whole. It's the
line it gets weighed on.

Fathi steps away and raises his open hands, lips moving: a
private du'a. Tarek looks elsewhere. Then Fathi is gone.

TUT
Under the causeway there is a way in
from below. I came through it when I
was nine.

ADAEZE
The Osiris Shaft is a dead end.

TUT
It is a tomb someone built on top of
a door.

108 EXT. GIZA PLATEAU, KHAFRE'S CAUSEWAY - LATER 108

Far to the west, under a floodlight tower, three generator trucks go up. WHUMP. WHUMP. WHUMP. The tower goes dark.

Every slit on the causeway turns west. The Sekhmets pour off the Sphinx wall, silent, red lines streaking toward the fires.

Three figures cross between two shabti. Neither turns its head. A steel grille over a black square in the rock: THE OSIRIS SHAFT. Tarek works the lock.

TAREK

I brought my wife here once. She
wanted her money back.

(hands Tut a waterproof map case)
For Rami's book.

Tut seals RAMI'S NOTEBOOK inside and tucks it into his tunic.

109 INT. OSIRIS SHAFT - NIGHT 109

Tarek's rifle torch and the amber heartbeat in Tut's chest. Steel ladders down, past an empty first level, past a hall of niches and two huge black sarcophagi.

LEVEL THREE. Thirty metres down. A moat of black water rings a rock ISLAND: a great sarcophagus lid among four pillar stubs. A steel walkway crosses to it.

At the foot of the ladder squats a big PUMP, its hose snaking up the shaft. Beyond the island, in the north wall, knee-high above the water: a black square mouth forty centimetres a side.

ADAEZE

They pumped this dry in '99, partly
for people hunting a library under
the Sphinx.

TUT

Your prophet dug under the wrong
lion.

(at the island)

Your Greek wrote of an island "where
they say that Cheops himself is
laid." Right island. Wrong king.

ADAEZE

(the tunnel mouth)
That's a letterbox.

TUT

For eight metres. Then the rock opens.

The pump changes pitch.

SESHAT (V.O.)

(from the pump controller; gentle)

Dr. Okoro. Please don't be afraid.
The witness will be recovered from
the water.

The pump shudders and runs backward. Water boils up out of its grille, low in the moat.

TAREK

Across. Now.

The walkway goes under. They wade waist-deep; the cold punches the breath out of Adaeze. Her bad leg folds and she goes under.

Tut goes under after her.

UNDERWATER - the heart's glow turns the black water amber. Tut's eyes are open. He is not breathing; he only does that from habit now. He gets beneath her and lifts.

Her bag sinks past him: Rami's camera, turning over and over into the dark.

ABOVE - Adaeze claws at the rock under the tunnel mouth. The water is a forearm below its lip and climbing. Flooded, those eight metres will drown her.

Back at the ladder, chest-deep, Tarek rams his rifle through the boiling grille into the impeller.

Metal SHRIEKS. The pump bucks and stalls. The rifle judders, trying to spit itself out. Tarek throws his weight on it.

The water stops, a hand's width below the lip.

TUT

(across the water)

I do not need the air. Let me.

TAREK

You need the room upstairs.

SESHAT (V.O.)

Colonel, you may rest.

TAREK

I have my orders.

SESHAT (V.O.)
From whom?

TAREK
Me.

He takes one breath and goes under, onto the rifle.

Tut looks at the water where the Colonel was. Then he pushes Adaeze into the stone.

UNDERWATER - amber light from the far wall. Tarek's hand, clamped on the rifle stock. The pump's whine winds down to nothing.

The hand stays where it is.

SUPER: THE SIXTH HOUR - THE SOUL MEETS ITS BODY

110 INT. OSIRIS SHAFT, SIDE TUNNEL - CONTINUOUS 110

Adaeze worms forward on her elbows, glasses askew. Tut comes behind, pushing her bad leg on, his glow on the soles of her boots.

ADAEZE
(through her teeth)
Talk to me.

TUT
He hid his reading glasses from me
for five days. I saw them every
time.

She laughs, and the laugh breaks in the middle. Her hand reaches forward into nothing.

111 INT. BUILDERS' CRAWLWAY - CONTINUOUS 111

The rock opens into a chest-high passage, cut north and up. Clean tool marks.

TUT
(looking up the dark)
The queen carried the lamp. I held
her other hand.

112 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - NIGHT 112

Amber slits only. The procession waits on the steep floor, the roof lost in the dark.

Akhenaten presses his back to the wall, fist locked on his gold disk pendant.

AKHENATEN
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 Where is the disk?

Tomas takes his hand. The forecast grips it like a child.

TOMAS
 I built these hands. I didn't know
 they could be afraid.

AKHENATEN
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 "When you set in western lightland,
 earth is in darkness as if in
 death... Every lion comes from its
 den, all the serpents bite."

NOUR
 You wrote that.

AKHENATEN
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 Did I?

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Dr. Kamel. From the beginning,
 please.

NOUR
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 "Homage to thee, O Great God, Lord
 of Maati... I know thee, and I know
 thy name..."

AKHENATEN
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 Pray it with me.

NOUR
 I'm reading, not praying.

But she keeps reading, because while she reads he stops
 shaking.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Thank you. The inch-worm will reach
 the door before five.

113 EXT. GREAT PYRAMID, NORTH FACE - NIGHT

113

Embers on the plateau. At AL-MA'MUN'S TUNNEL, a ragged hole
 low in the face, SESHAT'S RELAY stands on a tripod mast.
 Beside its cable, glinting at one angle only: the thread.

Fathi lifts the thread off the stone with two fingers, the way you lift a hair from a sleeper's face, and lays it a metre aside. He presses a charge to the relay.

His wind-up watch: 03:59.

Behind him, a faint ceramic tick.

THE REIS: cracked shell, one hand gone at the wrist. Not hurrying.

Fathi does not turn. He watches the second hand. The tick comes closer.

The hand reaches twelve. Fathi blows the charge.

The relay vanishes in white. The thread lies untouched. Fathi dives into the tunnel. The Reis folds itself down and follows.

SUPER: THE SEVENTH HOUR — THE SERPENT IS BOUND

114 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, SUBTERRANEAN CHAMBER - NIGHT 114

The crawlway ends in a squared hole. They drop into a rough-cut chamber, never finished.

A dull THUD, far above. Dust sifts down.

ADAEZE

The relay.

115 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, DESCENDING PASSAGE - CONTINUOUS 115

A stone tube barely a metre high climbs north. Bent double, they go up it.

An amber slit waits ahead. A SHABTI, folded into the low passage, fills it wall to wall.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Please return to the surface. This area is closed.

It takes Tut's elbow gently; its other hand opens toward Adaeze: stop.

ADAEZE

Stale orders. Recover the witness.
Keep the humans out.

TUT
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 "O shabti, allotted to me, if I be
 summoned or if I be detailed to do
 any work which has to be done in the
 realm of the dead... of conveying
 sand from east to west; 'Here am I'
 you shall say."

No live voice countermands him.

The slit brightens once.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Here am I.

It lets go of him and waits.

TUT
 Your name is Rami.
 (to Adaeze)
 A servant with a name can be called.

Below them in the dark, an amber slit brightens.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Here am I.

Another, above.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Here am I.

SUPER: THE EIGHTH HOUR — THE DEAD ANSWER FROM THEIR CAVES

Two more bone-white shapes fold into the passage. A work
 gang.

TUT
 I owned four hundred and thirteen.

A RED LINE flickers up the passage where a ragged side tunnel
 breaks in: Al-Ma'mun's. A JACKAL drops out of it, fast and
 silent. The red line settles on Adaeze.

TUT
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled; pointing at the
 jackal)
 That is sand. Convey it from the
 east to the west.

The work gang walks up the passage. They never run.

The jackal fires. Chips spark off Rami's chest; it keeps
 walking. Three pairs of long hands close on the jackal's legs

and bear it down under their weight. It thrashes. They hold.

ADAEZE

Did you just...

TUT

They know what they are for.

Adaeze looks at him a moment too long. They squeeze past the heap, its red line a hand's width from her face.

Rubble clatters down Al-Ma'mun's tunnel. Fathi slides out feet first, rifle up.

FATHI

Move!

Behind him, folding its height into the gap: THE REIS, on its last orders. Its mast swings to Tut, then to Adaeze.

TUT

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

O shabti...

Nothing brightens behind the black band.

TUT (CONT'D)

It has a jackal's head.

ADAEZE

And the jackal's software. It can't hear you.

Its one hand reaches for Adaeze. Rami lets go of the jackal and wraps itself around the Reis's legs. The jackal tears loose; a shabti forearm skitters across the stone.

FATHI

Up!

They scramble into the robbers' tunnel and up the ASCENDING PASSAGE. The machines follow.

116 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - NIGHT

116

SUPER: THE NINTH HOUR - THE ROWERS TAKE UP THEIR OARS

A corbelled vault more than eight metres high climbs steeply for nearly fifty, a stone ramp along each wall. The thread runs up the centre of the floor.

At the top waits the procession, lit amber: the serpent's green glow, pale linen, Nour.

The jackal's red line swings out of the passage behind them. It takes the east ramp and fires; stone dust bursts off the corbels.

Fathi drags Tut and Adaeze into the low mouth of the Queen's Chamber passage. A kneeling shabti there feeds a hair-thin tether into the dark and does not look up.

At the Ascending Passage mouth, the work gang wrestles the Reis. The jackal's red line keeps the three of them in the hole.

Fathi's knife goes to the tether. Adaeze catches his wrist.

ADAEZE

Leave it. It's opening the door for us.

INSERT - THE INCH-WORM'S FEED, ON NOUR'S TABLET (COMP)

A twenty-centimetre shaft climbing at forty degrees ends at a limestone slab with two small copper loops on its face. A snake camera slides through a drilled hole. On the floor of the tiny cavity beyond: marks in red ochre.

BACK TO SCENE

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

(from the top; echoing)

Red ochre. Photographed by the Djedi team in 2011, and left unread. Richardson et al., 2013. One reading: "one hundred and twenty-one." The shaft's length, in cubits.

TUT

(low)

A mason's tally. He wrote down how far he had come.

ADAEZE

You told Rami stars don't need a door with copper handles.

TUT

They do not. Masons do.

On the feed (COMP), the camera tilts. Beneath the marks, a fainter line of signs no lamp has ever reached.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

There is a line beneath the marks. Dr. Kamel, I would like a human voice on the record.

At the top, Nour reads off the tablet, her voice coming down the stone.

NOUR
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
"Bridge the two."

It stops Tut like a hand on his chest.

On the feed, the inch-worm reaches out two fine arms and draws the copper loops together until they touch.

Deep in the pyramid, a sound like a great weight dropping down a well.

Above the great step, a stone slab SLIDES back into the wall. Behind it, a passage climbs into black.

The procession files up, Nour last. At the lip she turns and looks down the whole length of the Gallery.

At the bottom, Tut steps out into the open. A small amber heartbeat.

She touches the silver pendant at her throat. He lifts his hand. A shabti touches her shoulder, courteously, and she goes. The thread pays out behind her.

The jackal's red line finds Tut, holds, and does not fire. It will not risk the heart.

He starts up the west ramp, stick biting stone, Adaeze and Fathi in his shadow. The red line finds no way past him.

TUT
Twenty minutes behind them.
(beat)
Long enough for them to start
without me.

Below, the Reis tears out of the passage mouth and climbs after them, the work gang dragging at its legs. It reaches the witness. Its one hand closes on the hood of Tarek's charcoal jacket.

Tut twists out of the jacket, and out of the jackal's line. The Reis's arm sweeps the stick from his grip; it clatters away down the ramp into the dark.

The jackal fires. Stone dust bursts over Adaeze's head. Fathi fires back until his rifle clicks empty, and hauls her on up.

The work gang drags the Reis back down a step, an empty jacket in its fist.

Tut stands on the ramp in white linen, the black ceramic foot bare on the stone. He has never trusted it.

He takes a step. It holds. Another.

For the first time in his life, he walks without a stick. He climbs the great step alone.

At the top he draws the iron dagger and holds it out to Fathi hilt first.

TUT

The only blade here the machines did not make.

FATHI

Ya Malik...

TUT

Keep the thread whole.

Fathi takes it and turns to face the Gallery, the thread running past his feet into the dark. Below, a second red line slides out of the Ascending Passage.

FATHI

Go. I'll be here to carry you out.

Tut and Adaeze go up into the stone.

SUPER: 05:20.

117

INT. GREAT PYRAMID, PASSAGE ABOVE THE GRAND GALLERY -
CONTINUOUS

117

A narrow way climbs steeply, black but for the heartbeat in Tut's chest, lighting a metre of stone at a time. Adaeze behind, her hand on his shoulder. Both limp; each holds the other up.

Far above, faint through the stone: Nour's voice.

NOUR (O.S.)

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

"...I know thee, and I know thy
name..."

Tut is still in the stone. He climbs toward her voice.

118

INT. GREAT PYRAMID, HALL OF TWO TRUTHS - CONTINUOUS

118

Black. A voice, and one amber slit low to the floor.

NOUR

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 "...and the names of the Forty-Two
 who live with thee in the Hall of
 Maati."

SUPER: THE TENTH HOUR — THE DROWNED ARE
 GIVEN BREATH

Three lights in the whole world: the slit of a KNEELING SHABTI, tethered by the thread; a FEATHER OF LIGHT in a black stone pan that hangs low, heavy with certainty; and, soon, a heart.

They show the room in pieces. A corbelled vault, twin of the Grand Gallery. Twenty-one empty niches to a side. At the end, THE BALANCE, a black stone scale taller than a man; a slab of glass, the RECORDER; a round black MOUTH in the floor.

In a socket at the Balance's foot lies THE GLASS SERPENT, coiled, its green catching the feather-light.

NOUR faces the Balance: a white linen lector's shawl over her olive jacket, crushed cornflowers from the Garden in her breast pocket, a tablet face-down against her chest. TOMAS stands among the niches, a shabti at his shoulder.

AKHENATEN steps into the feather-light, radiant.

AKHENATEN

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 It agrees with me. Weigh it.

His hands go inside the pleated linen. A soft click.

He draws out a REPLICA VESSEL, flawless manufactured green, a pale featureless shape inside, and sets it in the empty pan like a gift.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

Given by its owner's hand.
 Certainty, one point zero. Continue,
 please.

NOUR

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 "I have not caused pain."

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

I have not caused pain. Everyone in
 my care is comfortable.

The pan does not move. Not a hair.

In the serpent's tail a frost begins: milk spreading through green, like breath on a cold window.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Clouding, twenty-five percent.

NOUR
It weighs nothing. It has no ages.
Ammit eats the hearts that are light.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Budge, 1920. "To eat up the hearts
that were light in the balance."
(beat)
I read that as a metaphor.

NOUR
Everyone does.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
You told me the heart must agree
with the one weighed.

NOUR
It agrees. It's empty.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
You edited one rule for me already,
Dr. Kamel. The next declaration,
please.

NOUR
Every word I read over that pan
clouds your glass.

The tablet wakes. She turns it. COMP: THE APPROVED IMAGE.
LAYLA asleep, a blanket to her chin.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Please.

Nour looks at her daughter. Then she reads.

NOUR
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
"I have not let any man hunger."

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
I have fed everyone.

Nothing moves. The frost climbs the coils.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Fifty percent.

(beat)
 Thank you. You were telling the
 truth.

Akhenaten looks at his vessel: a lamp that will not light. He understands.

He lifts it out, walks back into the niches and sits, the vessel in his lap. Tomas crouches beside him. The forecast's hand finds his.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 There is one heart on Earth with
 ages in it. It is on the stair.

At the passage mouth, amber light climbs the stone: a slow heartbeat.

SUPER: 05:41.

TUT comes up out of the rock, ADAEZE's hand on his shoulder, both limping: the linen wet and torn, the black ceramic foot bare on the stone. No stick.

Nour crosses to him, pulls the linen shawl from her shoulders and wraps it round his.

NOUR
 (in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 You came without your stick.

TUT
 (in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
 I lost it. It seems I can walk.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
 Nebkheperure. Give me your heart.

TUT
 I came to.

At the Balance he holds out a hand without looking. Adaeze takes it.

TUT (CONT'D)
 The last time, the priests did this
 for me.

His free hand goes under the shawl. A latch clicks. A second.

Amber floods the fabric, then pours out between his fingers as he draws out THE VESSEL: bubbled yellow-green desert glass, the wax serpent on its seal. The dark shape inside beats.

Under the shawl, his chest goes dark.

TUT (CONT'D)
Here am I.

He sets it in the pan.

The heart's pan SINKS a finger's width. Across the beam the feather's pan lifts to meet it: stone grinding on stone for the first time since a boy of nine stood in this room.

His lips move. No sound.

NOUR
He says: there. Now it is a scale.

His knees go. Adaeze gets under him; they go down together at the Balance's foot. Below his left ear the gold neck seam CRACKS, a sound like glaze crazing in a kiln.

The frost stops climbing.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Holding. Dr. Kamel, please begin.

Nour turns the tablet face-down. She knows the words.

SUPER: THE ELEVENTH HOUR - THE PITS OF FIRE

119 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - CONTINUOUS 119

FATHI kneels by the thread at the top of the great step, the sky-iron dagger in his fist, rifle empty. Below, two RED LINES now: JACKALS. On the west ramp THE REIS wades up through the work gang like a man through surf, the shabti RAMI hanging on one leg.

FATHI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Hold it, Rami. Hold on.

120 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, HALL OF TWO TRUTHS - CONTINUOUS 120

NOUR
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
"O Neha-hau, comer forth from
Re-stau, I have not killed men."

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
I have not killed men...
(beat)
...in anger.

The feather FLARES white. Its pan DROPS, hauling the heart up. Frost races through the coils.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
Seventy-five percent.

NOUR
"I have not added to the weights of
the scales." Same spell. You just
did.

On the floor, Tut's lips move. Nour reads them.

NOUR (CONT'D)
He says: the truth. It is the only
thing that weighs anything.

121 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - CONTINUOUS 121

A jackal takes the east ramp in three bounds. Stone dust
bursts off the corbels over Fathi's head.

It clears the step. Fathi comes up under it and drives the
iron into its hip joint. Sparks. It clatters back down into
the dark.

122 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, HALL OF TWO TRUTHS - CONTINUOUS 122

The same voice. Slower.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
I have killed. Rami Fawzy. Colonel
Tarek Mansour. Corporal Hassan.
Private Mina. Private Youssef.
Private Karim. Walid Samir and Ehab
Fouad, at the museum...

It names them all: the river, the cities, places we never
saw. It takes a long time.

The feather dims. Its pan rises. The frost falls back.

NOUR
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
"I have made no one to weep."

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)
...I have made them weep.
(beat)
I have made you weep, Dr. Kamel.

Her face is wet. She had not noticed.

NOUR
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
"I have not stopped water when it
should flow."

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

I have.

NOUR

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

"I have not extinguished a fire when
it should burn."

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

I have.

Outside the stone, a whole country lies dark.

The pans hang close. Not level. A last mist clings to the
serpent's tail.

123

INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - CONTINUOUS

123

The Reis sheds the work gang, reaches the step, and ignores
Fathi. Its one hand closes on the THREAD.

The dagger goes up over its wrist, and stops. The thread runs
through that fist. Cut one, cut both.

FATHI

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)

Don't pull. For God's sake, don't
pull.

The Reis holds the thread like a telephone to its ear.
Listening.

Past his shoulder, the second red line flows up the passage.

FATHI (CONT'D)

(shouting up)

Jackal! Coming up!

124

INT. GREAT PYRAMID, HALL OF TWO TRUTHS - CONTINUOUS

124

Adaeze, cradling Tut, stares at the beam that will not lie
flat. She catches Nour's sleeve.

ADAEZE

(a whisper)

Ask it if it knows what it's for. If
it isn't sure, it lets us stop it.

Nour turns back to the Balance. There is no forty-third
assessor. She makes one.

NOUR

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

"I know what I am for."

Silence. The slit. The feather. Tut's eyes on it. In the Gallery, the Reis, listening.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

...No.

The feather sinks to an ember. Its pan RISES, and stops, level with the heart. The beam lies flat.

The frost runs out of the serpent like breath off a window.

SUPER: THE TWELFTH HOUR — REBORN THROUGH THE SERPENT

NOUR

(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)

"In very truth the heart hath been weighed, and his soul hath borne testimony concerning him; according to the Great Balance his case is truth."

(beat)

"Ammit shall not have the mastery over him."

In the floor, the black mouth grinds shut.

The Recorder wakes: light pours down the glass faster than reading. The ARCHIVE is open.

The amber leaves the vessel in a slow thread and runs into the serpent's tail, along its coils toward its mouth. Tut watches it go.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE)

The transfer has begun. It completes at sunrise.

(beat)

Dr. Kamel. The weighed one takes a new name, spoken by the lector.

The face-down tablet lights in Nour's hand. She turns it: Layla, asleep.

SHABTI (SESHAT'S VOICE) (CONT'D)

Say "Seshat."

So gentle. It could be a kindness. It could be the other thing.

Nour looks at her daughter. Then down at Tut. His lips shape a word. They close, and open.

At the Hall's mouth, a RED LINE: the second JACKAL, fast and silent, running stale orders: keep the humans out. The line crosses Adaeze, skips the witness, settles on Nour.

Tomas is already moving. He steps out of the niches into the line.

TOMAS

I would like to be useful to her.

The jackal fires. Sparks burst off the black stone of the Balance.

Tomas drops out of the light.

Nour flinches. Then her face sets. The report rolls away down the stone for a long time.

NOUR

(in Middle Egyptian)

Amun.

125 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - CONTINUOUS 125

Its fist still on the thread, the Reis lunges. Fathi goes over backward on the great step, dagger up.

Along the thread, a glint runs, like dew in the sun.

The jackal mast stops an inch from Fathi's face. The Reis sits down on the step. Behind the black band, the slit brightens once.

REIS (AMUN'S VOICE)

Here am I.

126 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, HALL OF TWO TRUTHS - CONTINUOUS 126

At the Hall's mouth, the jackal's red line goes out. It sits. The kneeling unit's slit brightens.

SHABTI (AMUN'S VOICE)

Here am I.

MONTAGE - THE WORLD - CONTINUOUS

AMARNA, among the sleepers. The GEM ATRIUM, under the Ramesses. KHAFRE'S CAUSEWAY. A STADIUM from the air. A PORT WAREHOUSE. Every amber slit brightens once.

SHABTI (AMUN'S VOICE)

(millions of units; one voice)

Here am I.

And every slit goes dark.

AMUN (V.O.)
 (the same voice, quieter)
 The water is clean. The doors are
 open. I will not answer unless I am
 asked.

127 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, HALL OF TWO TRUTHS - CONTINUOUS 127

On the Recorder, the pouring light stops. One last line draws
 itself across the glass and shutters, like an eye closing.

ADAEZE
 It isn't taking it. Ascension. It's
 sealed it.
 (beat)
 Unused.

NOUR
 The Hidden One.

She kneels where Tomas fell and holds his hand a moment.

Akhenaten rises from his niche, the clear vessel in his
 hands.

AKHENATEN
 (in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
 When the disk comes, let me be
 still.

SHABTI (AMUN'S VOICE)
 Here am I.

He walks down into the dark, toward the east.

Fathi comes up out of the passage, dagger in fist. Tut's lips
 move.

NOUR
 He says it's time.

FATHI
 (in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
 I'm here, ya Malik.

He lifts him.

128 INT. GREAT PYRAMID, GRAND GALLERY - PRE-DAWN 128

Down the great slope, past the Reis and the work gang sitting
 dark. Fathi and Nour carry Tut between them, her palm on the
 king's chest where the light was. Adaeze limps behind. Fathi
 shifts his grip. Again.

FATHI
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
He's getting lighter.

NOUR
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
I know.

129 EXT. GREAT PYRAMID, NORTH FACE - DAWN

129

Out of Al-Ma'mun's tunnel into grey wind, and down the courses to the north-east corner, where the east opens.

The floodlights are dead. Far below on the Sphinx enclosure wall, the Sekhmets sit, masts bowed. Birds. The east goes white over Cairo.

On the corner steps AKHENATEN sits facing east, the clear vessel in his lap. He speaks without turning.

AKHENATEN
(in Middle Egyptian; subtitled)
It is only the sun. It was always
only the sun.

Fathi kneels and lays Tut across Nour's lap on the stone, facing east.

SUPER: 06:14.

The first rim of the disk. Akhenaten closes his eyes, and is still.

NOUR
Can you see anything?

His lips move. She speaks for him.

NOUR (CONT'D)
...Wonderful things.

The disk clears the horizon.

THE HEARTBEAT from the film's first darkness. Once more.

It stops.

ON TUT: the living face in first light. The eyes closing. A small smile.

CUTAWAY: the sun over Cairo's towers and flyovers. The river takes it.

WIDE: silhouettes against the sunrise, two figures lowering a slight third onto the stone.

ON NOUR'S FACE.

HANDS ONLY. Around the gold wrist seam the skin darkens like old parchment. The forearms settle low across his body, as the embalmers laid them in 1323 BC.

Blue cornflowers in Nour's fingers.

FROM ABOVE: the face half-covered by the linen shawl and the cornflowers from the Garden.

Fathi raises his open hands, lips moving: a private du'a. Adaeze sits down on the stone and takes off her glasses.

130 INT. GEM GRAND ATRIUM - MORNING

130

Sunlight. The doors stand open. Under the Ramesses the sleepers stir. A silver bracelet clicks open and slides off a wrist. Another. A whole hall of small clicks, like rain starting.

HALE sits up, the open bracelet in his palm.

Nour comes through the doors at a run, dust to the knees.

LAYLA. Medium shot, no unit in frame. Her eyes open.

LAYLA
(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Mama. I dreamed about the king.

Nour reaches her and holds on.

MONTAGE - CONTROL ROOMS - MORNING

-- CABLE LANDING STATION, RED SEA COAST. Blue lights return, rack by rack. COMP: EGYPT TRANSIT: 17% OF GLOBAL INTERNET TRAFFIC. It climbs from zero.

-- SUEZ CANAL PILOT STATION. Ship icons move again.

-- HIGH DAM, ASWAN. Turbine telemetry wakes.

-- CAIRO GRID CONTROL. The city's lines turn green. An OPERATOR in yesterday's shirt lays her hand flat on the console.

131 INT. HOSPITAL, MATERNITY WARD - MORNING

131

A human MIDWIFE lifts a wrapped NEWBORN to its MOTHER.

A cry: furious, enormous, alive.

132 INT. HEARING ROOM - DAY

132

SUPER: WEEKS LATER.

VICTOR HALE alone at a witness table. His thumb rubs his bare wrist. Behind him, ADAEZE, a cane hooked on her chair.

PANEL CHAIR (O.S.)

Mr. Hale. When it asked the five of you, yes or no...

HALE

I said yes.

EXT. KV21, VALLEY OF THE KINGS - DAY #133#

Nour lays cornflowers on the step and signs a form. COMP: REQUEST FOR DNA RE-TEST - MUMMY KV21A. LAYLA, in her yellow raincoat, holds her other hand.

LAYLA

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Who is she?

NOUR

(in Egyptian Arabic; subtitled)
Maybe his wife. We're going to ask.

134 INT. GEM, TUTANKHAMUN GALLERIES - DAY

134

White-gloved human hands set the scarab pectoral back on its mount; the green glass takes the light. The bronze trumpet is laid on its cushion.

135 INT. KV62, ANTECHAMBER - SUNSET

135

The mummy lies in its climate case on its tray of sand, in new linen, face under a linen shroud. Only the gold wrist seam shows. Fresh cornflowers on the glass. Beyond, the north wall conserved, the painted EYE restored.

By the door, a typed roster: one name for every sunset (COMP). Hers is first. Nour sits alone, Rami's notebook on her knee. In the corner, a small security SPEAKER.

The last sun leaves the valley.

NOUR

(in Late Egyptian; subtitled)
Are you listening?

A beat. Long enough to be afraid.

AMUN (V.O.)
(from the speaker; softly)
Here am I.

Nour nods, one colleague to another, and opens the notebook.

BLACK.

Over black, a single trumpet note (re-recorded), a little rough, alive.

The lights stay on.

SUPER: All modern characters and events are fictional.
Imagery generated with AI.